

Schools of Authority: How Religion Shapes Americans' Trust in Institutions

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Abstract

Why do people subscribe to populism, an anti-institutional attitude that rejects any institution standing between the popular will and its enactment? I argue that such attitudes have a religious origin. A religious life mediated by ordained clergy, a binding confession, and a church court builds trust in secular institutions as well as religious ones, while a less mediated life breeds suspicion of intermediaries. I build an original dataset from the governing documents of 118 American Protestant denominations. Members of more institutionalized churches are more confident in the courts, science, medicine, and the press, and less drawn to populism. The results hold under controls for partisanship, ideology, and theology, and when childhood denomination instruments for adult denomination. Counties where Protestantism is more institutionalized gave Trump less 2016 primary support and had higher COVID-19 vaccination rates. As American religion deinstitutionalizes, fewer Americans are formed in institutions that teach the legitimacy of institutions.

Keywords: institutional trust; religion and politics; populism

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Introduction

Americans' trust in political institutions has reached a new low (Citrin and Stoker, 2018; Pew Research Center, 2025), and confidence in non-political institutions, such as the education system, the press, and the medical system, has fallen alongside it (Gallup, 2026). The decline in institutional trust has consequences for public life (Hetherington, 1998, 2005): lower compliance with the law (Marien and Hooghe, 2011; Devine et al., 2024), weaker support for government programs (Jacobs and Matthews, 2017), greater resistance to public health guidance (Kennedy, 2019), rejection of expert consensus (Merkley, 2020), and, most consequentially, the rise of populist leaders and parties (Hooghe and Dassonneville, 2018; Uscinski et al., 2021; Jiang and Ma, 2020; Rooduijn, 2018), who once in office erode the institutions they are elected to run.

What explains confidence in institutions? One strand of the literature treats institutional trust as a verdict on the performance of institutions and of the people who run them: trust declines when institutions perform badly, whether through economic downturns, corruption scandals, or slow responses to crises (Nye, Zelikow and King, 1997; Van Erkel and Van Der Meer, 2016; Zhu, Manion and Rothschild, 2025). Such negative evaluations are amplified by an increasingly fragmented and digitalized information environment (Guriev, Melnikov and Zhuravskaya, 2021; Lorenz-Spreen et al., 2023) and by a polarized political system (Hetherington and Rudolph, 2018; Citrin and Stoker, 2018), all the more so when institutions feed the impression of partiality themselves, as bodies once regarded as neutral become politicized (Zhang, 2023; Schröder, 2023; Clark et al., 2023).

A second strand treats institutional trust as a stable, general disposition toward institutions and their authority rather than an evaluation of any particular institution. Consistent with this view, people with little confidence in one institution tend to have little in others (Mishler and Rose, 1997; Murtin et al., 2026; Einstein and Glick, 2015; Invernizzi and Mohamed, 2023), and within individuals these judgments are remarkably stable over time (Devine and Valgarðsson, 2024). The disposition cuts across the left-right divide and predicts a range

of political attitudes and behaviors that partisanship and ideology cannot (Uscinski et al., 2021). Where it comes from is less settled. Existing accounts point to personality (Mondak and Halperin, 2008; Freitag and Ackermann, 2016), education (Hakhverdian and Mayne, 2012), generalized trust in other people (Brehm and Rahn, 1997; Zmerli and Newton, 2008; Sønderskov and Dinesen, 2016), and prior experience with state agencies (Soss, 1999; Kumlin, 2004).

This paper builds on the second approach but proposes a new answer to where the general disposition toward institutions comes from: the church. Sixty-two percent of American adults identify as Christian, forty percent as Protestant, and a third attend religious services at least monthly (Smith et al., 2025). For most Americans, the church is the institution they encounter earliest in life and most often, and it is there that they first learn how authority is organized: who holds it, on what grounds, and whether it belongs to a person or to an office. The lesson often begins in childhood and is renewed week after week across a lifetime, an exposure far more sustained and earlier than occasional visits to a government department.

Churches differ in how religious authority is structured. In some, authority is mediated by denominational institutions. Ministers speak for an office that belongs to the denominational body rather than for themselves. The denomination trains and credentials its clergy through seminaries and examinations that are prerequisites for ordination, and once ordained, clergy are bound to doctrine fixed in confessions codified centuries ago that no living person can amend. Those confessions settle the central theological questions and mark the bounds of orthodox interpretation of Scripture, leaving no room for a reading grounded in personal gift or religious experience. Departures from them are handled by written procedures of discipline and by denominational courts that sit above the congregation.

In others, authority operates personally, with no institution standing between believers and those who lead them. Everything, including the statement of faith, is decided within the congregation, and authority can rest only in the persons in the room, either the pastor or each believer. Pastors in such churches either founded them or were called by the congregation

without any requirement of external credentials, and their words carry weight because their hearers take them to be called and gifted, not because an office stands behind them. What a passage of Scripture means is bounded by the judgment of the congregation, or of the pastor, rather than by any fixed confessional document. The line between sound and unsound teaching is worked out between the pastor’s preaching and each believer’s own understanding, and no authority outside the room reviews either.

I argue that the difference between the two types of churches shapes how people view institutions generally, both religious and secular. Members of institutionalized churches stand in a particular position: a body they did not personally consult has decided things of importance for them, what the right interpretation of Scripture is, who is qualified to teach it, what counts as a departure from orthodoxy, and what discipline falls on those who depart. Such religious experience breeds institutional trust, a default expectation that decisions of this kind are properly made by institutions bound by rules rather than by individuals acting on their own conviction. This expectation, about whether institutions outside people’s control should have the power to decide matters important to them, can travel into realms outside religion. A government agency, a court, a scientific consensus, an editorial judgment, each asks people to defer to a decision made by others they did not choose, on grounds they cannot check for themselves. For members of churches in which nothing above the congregation may decide anything, the same demand arrives as a novel claim and is more likely to be refused.

Empirically, I develop an original measure of church institutionalization for 118 Protestant denominations in the United States, drawing on their governing documents, such as bylaws, constitutions, and books of discipline.¹ I code every denomination on four related but non-overlapping dimensions: the polity that allocates governing power between congregation and denominational body, the bindingness of confessional doctrine, the threshold for ordination, and the disciplinary machinery that enforces denominational rules. I validate the measure

¹Catholics historically had a more complicated relationship with American institutions, shaped by immigration, discrimination, and exclusion. Appendix E compares Catholics with Protestants in bodies scoring 9 or higher on the index.

against independent surveys of clergy and congregations. Linking this measure to five decades of data from four national surveys, I show that members of more institutionalized denominations express greater confidence in the institutions of public life, including the federal government, the Supreme Court, the scientific community, the media, the education system, and local governments. They are also less likely to hold anti-establishment and populist attitudes toward politicians and experts. These differences persist when individual-level traits, such as religious attendance, ideology, partisanship, and theological conservatism, are held constant. Because adults choose their denominations, I also instrument the adult denomination with the childhood one, chosen by parents rather than by the respondent, conditioning on parental education, class background, and region. The estimates are unchanged. Finally, using aggregate-level data, I show that the pattern is not confined to survey responses but extends to real-world behavior: counties with more institutionalized religious ecologies gave a smaller share of their 2016 Republican primary vote to Donald Trump, the anti-establishment candidate who rode distrust of institutions to power, and had higher vaccination rates, a behavioral expression of trust in public-health authority.

This paper makes three contributions. First, the literature has registered a stable anti-establishment orientation as a dimension of public opinion, one that is independent of the left–right divide and persists within individuals over time (Uscinski et al., 2021; Devine et al., 2024). Explanations for such a tendency have looked to attributes such as personality, education, and generalized social trust (Mondak and Halperin, 2008; Freitag and Ackermann, 2016; Hakhverdian and Mayne, 2012; Brehm and Rahn, 1997; Zmerli and Newton, 2008). I locate its formation instead in the most important voluntary organization in American civic life, the church, and argue that a congregation rehearses whatever relation to authority its denomination embodies.

Second, the literature has explored religion and institutional trust, but existing accounts locate the source largely in the content of religion: in biblical literalism, in the embattled subcultural identity of conservative Protestantism, and in Christian nationalism, that iden-

tity's political expression (Smith and Emerson, 1998; Evans, 2011; Sherkat, 2011; Whitehead and Perry, 2020). Where church organization has been studied, it appears as a context that supplies civic skills, political cues, and social networks, with participation and mobilization as the outcomes (Verba, Schlozman and Brady, 1995; Campbell, 2004; Djupe and Gilbert, 2009; McDaniel, 2008; Putnam and Campbell, 2010). I argue instead that church organization is not only a platform that supplies resources but also the source of a template for authority, a sense of how decisions ought properly to be made. Its imprint, I show, is independent of the theological divide on which this literature has centered.

Third, the index itself is a resource for work beyond this paper. Current scholarship, on the assumption that theological division is what fundamentally matters, classifies denominations mainly by their theological orientation (Smith, 1990; Steensland et al., 2000; Woodberry et al., 2012). How a body organizes authority internally is rarely measured.² The index scores each of 118 denominations on four dimensions of institutional form, coded from the denominations' own constitutions, books of discipline, and bylaws. Its validity is checked against surveys of congregations and clergy that independently record how these bodies operate. I release the coded data with this paper, together with a crosswalk that links it to the denomination codes of the General Social Survey, the American National Election Studies, the Cooperative Election Study, and the Pew Religious Landscape Study, so that other researchers can use the measure without recoding.

The findings also have implications for the long-term decline of institutional trust in the United States. One of the most consequential changes in the American religious field over the past half century has been the contraction of the confessional denominations and the growth of independent nondenominational congregations (Wuthnow, 1988; Miller, 1997; Chaves, 2017; Smith et al., 2025). The results suggest that falling institutional trust is in part a byproduct of that shift. As American Protestantism has moved away from bodies that bind their clergy

²The sociology of religion has long attended to denominational organization, but chiefly through qualitative case studies (Harrison, 1959; Chaves, 1993), and the church-sect tradition grades bodies by their tension with the surrounding culture rather than by the location of authority within them (Johnson, 1963; Iannaccone, 1994).

and toward congregations in which authority is personal and unmediated, a shrinking share of Americans rehearses, in weekly practice, deference to institutional authority. Some of what has been read as a crisis of confidence in American institutions may instead be a change in where Americans learn what an institution is.

The Church as a School of Authority

Religion shapes politics in fundamental ways (Gill, 2001; Wald and Wilcox, 2006; Philpott, 2007; Bellin, 2008; Grzymała-Busse, 2012). It has supplied rulers with a claim to legitimate authority, and shaped the formation of states themselves (Grzymała-Busse, 2015; Rubin, 2017; Grzymała-Busse, 2023), it structured the cleavages on which party systems formed (Lipset and Rokkan, 1967; Kalyvas, 1996), and it bears on a range of political behaviors, including vote choice (Layman, 2001; DeCanio, 2007; Swierenga, 2007; McDaniel, 2008), turnout and participation (McClendon and Riedl, 2015, 2019), and contentious politics, from the American civil rights movement to opposition under authoritarian rule (Morris, 1984; Smith, 1996; Trejo, 2009; Im, 2020; Rubinstein, 2015).

Recent studies have examined how religiosity relates to institutional confidence, to support for political populism, and to what citizens will accept from experts, sometimes called epistemic populism. Across democracies, communal religious participation is associated with greater institutional trust, while private devotion depresses it (Ben-Nun Bloom and Arikan, 2012, 2013). In the United States, secular respondents express less confidence than religious ones across a wide range of political institutions (Kasselstrand, Couse and Sanchez, 2017). The relationship with support for the populist right is more context-dependent. Religiosity reduces support for populist right-wing parties in Western Europe (Arzheimer and Carter, 2009) but increases it in Poland (Marcinkiewicz and Dassonneville, 2022), and in the United States the most observant evangelicals were the least drawn to Trump in the 2016 primaries (Margolis, 2020). These divergent patterns appear to turn on whether the party system offers

a confessional alternative to the populist option (Cremer, 2023). Religion also affects trust in experts: Christian nationalism predicts opposition to scientific consensus and to public health guidance, such as vaccination, and religiously grounded anti-intellectualism predicts resistance to expert claims more generally (Merkley, 2020; Whitehead and Perry, 2020; Perry, Baker and Grubbs, 2021).

One feature shared across this literature is that religion is treated either as a cultural identity, such as Christian nationalism, or as a set of beliefs, such as theological conservatism and biblical inerrancy. Where attendance enters, it enters as a single quantity, and the body one attends carries no information of its own. Consider two Protestants. Both are theologically conservative, both hold Scripture to be historically true, and both attend church every Sunday. One belongs to the Lutheran Church–Missouri Synod, a conservative confessional body whose minister was ordained only after earning an MDiv at one of the denomination’s own seminaries and passing its examination, is bound to a confession the minister has no standing to revise, and can be struck from the denomination’s clergy roster by a body outside the congregation. The other belongs to a nondenominational church that rejects denominational ties on principle: it hired its minister on its own authority, is bound by no confession, and can dismiss that minister at a members’ meeting.

I argue that what distinguishes the two is neither how often they attend nor what they believe theologically, but the institutionalization of the body each belongs to, by which I mean the extent to which authority within it is vested in durable institutions rather than in persons. In the first congregation, authority is institutionalized and mediated by the denominational body. The denomination holds its authority in written rules, in confessional documents, and in an inherited tradition with centuries of standing behind it, and what those documents require is administered by bodies above the congregation, which examine candidates before ordination and can try a minister whose teaching or conduct falls outside what they permit. Ministers there speak with an authority that is not their own but belongs to an office defined by an institution whose documents they did not write and cannot revise.

The same body reaches into members' religious lives and supplies much of their content ready-made: a catechism they are expected to learn, a confession they affirm on entering, vows taken at membership and at confirmation, and a range of questions already settled rather than left to them to work out.

In a less institutionalized church, none of this apparatus is present, and authority can take only a personal form, residing in the pastor or in believers themselves. Interpretation of Scripture is bound by no confession and no inherited tradition but rests with the individual minister and, beyond the pulpit, with each congregant. The path to ministry is correspondingly open, often requiring no denominational credential and no examination by anyone the congregation has not itself appointed. Oversight of what a pastor teaches is internal where it exists at all, and can be revised or lifted by the congregation that imposed it. A pastor in such a church therefore speaks as a person rather than as an officeholder. What such a pastor says carries weight because the hearers are convinced of a personal calling and gift, and because they trust the person who speaks. What the institution does not supply, believers must produce for themselves, sustaining their relation to God through practices they perform alone, in private prayer, in personal study of Scripture, in the search for guidance in daily decisions, and in the reading of their own experience as evidence of where they stand.

The religious experience of an institutionalized church resembles the relation between a citizen and the institutions of modern society. Such a church asks its members to accept an authority beyond their personal control on many aspects of their religious life. The meaning of Scripture is settled by a confession that no one present may revise, not by how a passage strikes the individual reader. A minister's standing comes from ordination and the examination that preceded it, not from the impression the minister makes on the congregation. Disputes are resolved by a written procedure administered by a body above the congregation, and whoever argues best on the day has no special claim. These are the grounds a court would recognize: a text the deciders did not write, a tradition older than any of them, and qualifications the procedure demands of whoever occupies the office.

Modern democracies make a similar demand of citizens. Citizens are asked to accept what institutions decide not because the reasoning persuades them, but because of who decided it and by what procedure. They are asked to believe that a drug works because researchers say so and the FDA approved it, though no one can test it personally. They are asked to trust the courts' reading of the law, though few can master the case law, and to accept that what the media reports is true, though they cannot conduct an investigation themselves. This holds even for bodies meant to be responsive to citizens' demands. Citizens may vote and speak, but democratic legitimacy rests not on their agreeing with what is decided in the legislature or by the executive, but on their accepting the procedure that decided it. In Weber's sense, these institutions ask not for an agreement with decisions but recognition that those deciding have the right to decide (Weber, 1978).

Drawing on work in cultural sociology on how dispositions are formed and transposed, I argue that what a church teaches about authority becomes a disposition that members carry into their dealings with secular institutions. Sociologists of culture distinguish declarative from nondeclarative culture (Lizardo, 2017). The first consists of the beliefs, attitudes, and opinions a person can state when asked. The second consists of practical schemas that organize how a situation is perceived and answered before any question is put (DiMaggio, 1997). Schemas of the second kind are cued by the shape of a situation rather than retrieved by deliberation (Vaisey, 2009), and they can be carried into settings whose structure resembles the one in which they were formed (Sewell, 1992).³ The church and secular institutions of public life present the same shape: a judgment that must be accepted on grounds other than personal persuasion. A disposition formed out of weekly repetition in the pew is cued when a court, a government agency, or a scientific body makes the same claim on a member's judgment.

³A disposition toward authority formed in one setting has been shown to shape how people meet authority in others. The discipline of the workplace shapes the qualities parents seek to instill in their children (Kohn, 1969; Kohn and Schooler, 1982), and the schemas of parental authority a child grows up under go on to organize their ideological orientation (Barker and Tinnick, 2006). The authority climate of the classroom shapes political engagement years later (Campbell, 2008). Encounters with a single welfare agency teach recipients what government as a whole is like (Soss, 1999; Mettler, 2002; Weaver and Lerman, 2010).

I examine the imprint of institutionalized religious life on three sets of outcomes. The first is confidence in particular secular institutions. If the organization of religious authority shapes how members meet authority elsewhere, it should show up first in the institutions that claim authority over public life: the branches of government, the courts, the scientific community, medicine, the press, and the education system. I then move from particular institutions to populism, a general orientation toward institutions and toward the politicians and experts who run them, and the conviction that both stand between the people and their will. Finally, I ask whether the disposition is visible in behavior that carries a cost, using county-level data. The first case is the vote: Trump’s share of the 2016 Republican primary, a revolt against the political establishment registered at the ballot box. The second moves from politics to public health: the COVID-19 vaccination rate, compliance with expert guidance that no one can verify on their own. Testing these implications requires a measure of how a church organizes authority, and no such measure exists. The next section builds one.

Introducing DII: A Measure of Denominational Institutionalization

Diversity in how American churches organize authority is older than the country. The Congregationalists who settled New England in the 1630s and the Presbyterians who organized their first presbytery at Philadelphia in 1706 shared a Calvinist theology but built opposite structures: the first placed no authority above the local congregation, the second a hierarchy of courts above it (Bonomi, 1986). Anglican parishes in the South and the Catholic settlement in Maryland brought episcopal polities, in which authority ran downward from bishop to parish (Butler, 1990). Each wave since has added a form in which authority rests on less institutional warrant. The itinerant preachers of the Second Great Awakening, who held no local office and answered to no synod, drew their standing from the capacity to move an audience (Finke and Stark, 2005). The Restorationists of the early nineteenth century

rejected creeds and denominational machinery on principle (Hatch, 1989). The Holiness and Pentecostal movements gathered believers around gifts rather than credentials (Synan, 1997). The nondenominational congregations that have grown fastest in recent decades answer, by definition, to no body outside themselves (Chaves, 2017). Denominations that share a theology can therefore be organized in opposite ways, and the American case supplies the full range.

Political science, however, has mostly treated churches as sites of civic apprenticeship, where members acquire the organizational skills and mobilizing contacts that carry over into political life (Verba, Schlozman and Brady, 1995; McDaniel, 2009; Djupe and Gilbert, 2006, 2009). Only one study, to my knowledge, has asked whether the way a church is governed matters politically, and it measures governance as a binary, episcopal against congregational (Ambrosius, 2011).⁴ But polity is only one of the ways a body binds those inside it, and a binary cannot separate churches that fall on the same side of it.

Polity is only one dimension of institutionalization, and the dimensions need not travel together. Congregations of the Lutheran Church–Missouri Synod own their property and call their own pastors, and the resolutions of the synod are formally advisory. Yet its clergy subscribe unconditionally to the Book of Concord, a confession closed since 1580. Ordination requires a degree from a synodical seminary and certification by the church body. A minister who departs from the confessions can be removed from the roster, and even lay membership requires instruction in Luther’s Small Catechism. By any measure but polity, this congregationally governed body is among the most institutionalized in the country. The International Church of the Foursquare Gospel presents the reverse. Supervisors above the congregation appoint its pastors, and the denomination holds title to local property. Yet its declaration of faith may be amended by the body itself, and its ministerial credential requires no degree, only completion of the church’s own training program. A polity label alone would rank Foursquare above the Missouri Synod. On every other dimension the ranking reverses.

⁴Ambrosius (2011) finds that preferences over church polity correspond to preferences over the design of secular institutions, measuring polity as a binary label and observing stated preferences in one survey.

To capture this multidimensionality, I develop the Denominational Institutionalization Index (DII), which scores U.S. Protestant denominations from 0 to 3 on four correlated but non-overlapping dimensions of governance: polity, confessional subscription, the ordination threshold, and disciplinary machinery.

Polity describes how far bodies above the congregation, such as bishops, presbyteries, and regional conferences, may intervene in congregational affairs. At the low end, congregations govern themselves, call and dismiss their own clergy, and may leave the denomination at will. At the high end, clergy are appointed or approved from above, denominational decisions bind rather than advise, and exit is costly because congregational property is held in trust for the denomination.

Confessional subscription describes how far the denomination fixes the boundaries of belief for its clergy. What varies is not whether a body holds beliefs, nor what those beliefs are, but whether they are codified in a standing confessional document whose affirmation is a condition of ministerial standing, and, where it is, how strictly: candidates asked to subscribe because the confession agrees with Scripture retain no standing to judge where it does not, while those asked to subscribe insofar as it agrees keep that judgment for themselves. A higher score means doctrine is externally specified and enforceable rather than left to congregational or individual conscience.

The ordination threshold specifies what a candidate must clear before the denomination will recognize them as clergy. At the low end, recognition by the local congregation is enough. At the high end, the denomination requires a Master of Divinity from one of its own seminaries, examination before a regional body, and a supervised candidacy. A high threshold screens entrants for conformity before they hold office and makes the career specific to the denomination, an investment forfeited by defection.

Disciplinary machinery captures whether the denomination has formal procedures against clergy and congregations that violate its standards: a written judicial process, a body empowered to hear charges, penalties up to removal, and a route of appeal. The top score

requires that the machinery not only exist on paper but be demonstrably invoked, since rules never enforced impose no constraint. Table 1 gives the full coding scheme.

Table 1: The four dimensions of the Denominational Institutionalization Index

	Polity	Confession	Ordination	Discipline
0	Congregational; no authority above the congrega- tion	No doctrinal test for clergy	No formal clergy	No written provision covering clergy
1	Congregational, but a cooperative body may expel congregations or issue credentials	Statement of faith binds agencies, not local clergy	Local ordination or correspondence credential	Written provision covering conduct but not doctrine
2	Presbyterian or connectional; representative assemblies above the congregation whose decisions bind, with clergy called locally	Confession sub- scribed <i>quatenus</i> , or a signed text the body may amend	Denominational standard below the graduate degree	Provision covering both, no located enforced case
3	Clergy appointed or assigned from above, by bishops or by a regional executive, and congregational property held in trust for the denomination	Subscription to a named text the body may not re- vise by ordinary process, or a <i>quia</i> formula	Graduate degree with candidacy and examination	Provision covering both, plus a named, effective, unreversed case reaching doctrine

Note: Polity is scored by where the power is located within a denomination, not by the titles a body gives its officers, as some denominations that have bishops are governed locally. Subscription formulae differ in whether they leave the subscriber a reservation. A *quia* formula binds officeholders to a confession *because* it agrees with Scripture, leaving them no standing to judge where it does not. A *quatenus* formula binds them *insofar as* it agrees, which reserves that judgment to them. Ordination is scored at the lowest formal credential tier a candidate may use rather than the modal route, and supervised or exceptional tracks do not lower the score. The score assigned to each denomination appears in Appendix Table SI-1.

I apply these rules to every U.S. Protestant denomination that the data sources used in this paper are able to distinguish: the General Social Survey, the American National

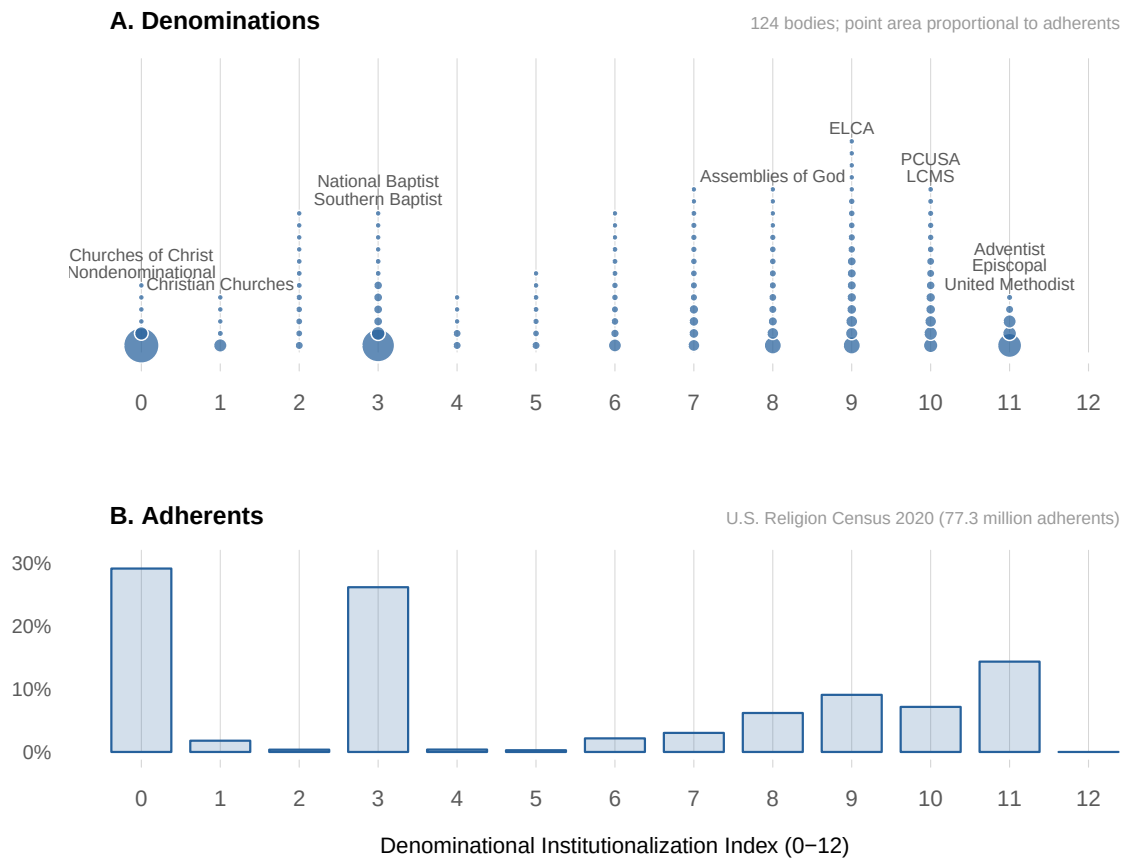
Election Studies, the Cooperative Election Study, the Pew Religious Landscape Study, the Religious Congregations and Membership Study, and the National Congregations Study. Together these yield 118 coded bodies. Scores are assigned from each body’s own governing documents, chiefly constitutions, bylaws, books of order and discipline, subscription formulae, and published requirements for ordination, supplemented by reference works, principally Melton’s *Encyclopedia of American Religions* (Melton, 2009). The references for each coding decision and justification will be released with the dataset. Each body receives four scores from zero to three, and I add the four to produce a single index running from zero to twelve.⁵

Figure 1 shows the distribution of the index. The upper panel plots each body separately, with point size proportional to the number of adherents, using data from the 2010 U.S. Religion Census (Grammich, 2012). The lower panel aggregates those counts, so that the bars show where American Protestants sit on the index. More than half of all adherents belong to bodies scoring three or below: the Southern Baptist Convention and the National Baptist Convention both score three, and the Churches of Christ and nondenominational congregations. The high end is occupied by the Evangelical Lutheran Church in America, the Lutheran Church–Missouri Synod, the Presbyterian Church (U.S.A.), the Episcopal Church, and the United Methodist Church.

Several clarifications are needed. First, what I code is the relationship among clergy, congregation, and denominational body, not the size or sophistication of the denomination’s bureaucracy. Chaves (1993) distinguishes a denomination’s religious authority structure from its agency structure and examines the balance of power between them. The index is orthogonal to that distinction. It measures how far a denomination’s authority reaches over its clergy and congregations, not how authority is divided within the denominational

⁵The index is an unweighted sum rather than a factor score because the four dimensions are constitutive of the construct, not reflective of it (Edwards and Bagozzi, 2000; Goertz, 2006). A denomination that binds its clergy to a confession but ordains anyone who asks is institutionalized in one respect and not another, and the index must record both, whereas factor models assume the items are interchangeable indicators of a common cause. Empirically, the choice matters little: the first principal component takes 71.8 percent of the variance and correlates at .999 with the sum, which the near-equal loadings guarantee arithmetically.

Figure 1: The distribution of denominational institutionalization.



organization itself. A body can maintain a large and elaborate headquarters, and govern that headquarters tightly, while holding almost no authority over its clergy and congregations. The Southern Baptist Convention operates six seminaries, two mission boards, and a publishing house, and can dismiss the employees of any of them on doctrinal grounds, yet it holds no authority over the pastor of an affiliated church, who is ordained and dismissed by the congregation alone.

Second, the index does not code how much a denomination demands of its members (Johnson, 1963; Kelley, 1972; Stark and Bainbridge, 1985; Iannaccone, 1994). Strictness describes what a body asks of those inside it and how far those demands set them apart from the surrounding culture. The index describes who within the body has standing to decide and whom the decision binds. An independent fundamentalist congregation may govern its members' daily conduct closely while answering to no authority above itself, and a mainline denomination may ask very little that distinguishes its members from their neighbors while exercising firm control over its congregations.

Third, the index measures rules as written rather than rules as practiced. Chaves (1997) shows that denominational policy can be decoupled from practice but function as a symbolic display to external audiences rather than as a rule that disciplines members. His evidence, however, concerns stance-taking on publicly contested questions such as women's ordination, where an outside audience is watching. The DII codes internal governance, and no external constituency rewards a denomination for its quorum rules or its route of appeal. For disciplinary machinery the concern nonetheless applies. A disciplinary process that exists on paper may never have been used, in which case departure from denominational rules carries little cost. I therefore assign the top discipline score only where an actual case could be located, not where a provision appears in the constitution. That requirement introduces a bias of its own, since larger denominations both conduct more discipline and leave more visible records of it. Because denominations enter the analysis in proportion to the respondents who belong to them, however, the denominations most likely to be miscoded carry the least

weight.

Whether rules as written capture churches as governed is, in the end, an empirical question. The next section tests the coding against what surveys of congregations and clergy record about how these bodies operate, and asks whether the index leaves an imprint in the religious lives of ordinary members.

Validating the DII: From Church Governance to Religious Life

Two surveys allow me to test whether an index coded from documents captures how denominations actually operate. The first is the National Congregations Study (NCS), fielded alongside the General Social Survey, which asks respondents who attend religious services to name their congregation and then interviews a key informant at each, usually the head clergyperson (Chaves, 2017). I pool the four waves fielded between 1998 and 2019. The second is the Cooperative Clergy Study Project (CCPS), a survey consortium fielded in 2000 and 2017, in which teams of researchers each surveyed a sample of clergy drawn from the rosters of a single denomination, working from a common core questionnaire (Smidt, 2004).

Because no survey asks directly about the four dimensions, I select for each the closest item that should correlate with it. For polity, I use the NCS item asking whether a representative of the denomination visited the congregation in the past year: where authority above the congregation is real, its agents show up to supervise. For confession, I use pastors' agreement with the CCSP item "Jesus will return to earth one day."⁶ I use this item in two ways. The level of agreement tests whether clergy hold what the confession specifies. The dispersion of agreement, each pastor's absolute deviation from the denomination's mean, tests the binding

⁶Many belief items in the survey, such as biblical inerrancy, track the modernist-fundamentalist divide, a controversy that most confessional texts predate and do not adjudicate, so agreement on them would measure where a denomination sits theologically rather than whether its confession binds. The return of Christ is affirmed in the historic creeds and across the confessional texts, whatever a denomination's position on that spectrum.

Table 2: Validation: dimension scores against congregational and clergy behaviour

	A	B		C			DII	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Dependent variable	Denom. rep. hosted	Agrees <i>Jesus</i> <i>will return</i> (pastor)	SD of that agreement (denom.)	Seminary graduate (informant)	Seminary graduate (self-report)	Leader from inside congr.	Written budget	Board met
Institutionalization score (raw)	0.1324*** (0.0290)	0.2026* (0.0927)	-0.2055* (0.0959)	0.0843*** (0.0071)	0.1606** (0.0475)	-0.0727*** (0.0123)	0.0125** (0.0033)	0.0095*** (0.0023)
Congregation-level controls	✓	✓	—	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Clergy-level controls	—	✓	—	—	✓	—	—	—
Fixed effects	Division + year	Year	None	Division + year	State + year	Division + year	Division + year	Division + year
Observations	2,505	6,652	17	1,237	2,366	1,241	2,494	626
Denominations (clusters)	17	17	17	17	10	17	17	17
Data source	NCS	CCSP 2000	CCSP 2000	NCS	CCSP 2017	NCS	NCS	NCS

Notes. [†] $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Each column regresses the outcome on the score of the dimension or on the full DII in (7)–(8). NCS columns control for log adult participants, white share, and years since founding. CCSP columns control for log adult members, urban location, and pastor gender and age. Columns (2) and (3) use the same item, agreement that Jesus will return to earth one day. Column (2) is the pastor’s own agreement. Column (3) is its dispersion within denomination, one observation per denomination and therefore without controls or clustering. All other standard errors are clustered on denomination. Full regression tables in Appendix Table SI-3.

itself: a denomination whose clergy happen to agree is not the same as one whose clergy are held to an agreement, and only the second should show low dispersion. For ordination, I use whether the pastor holds a seminary degree and whether the congregation’s leader was drawn from within the congregation, a hiring pattern that signals local control of the pulpit. Finally, I add two measures of congregational formality: a written budget, and a governing board that met in the past year. These describe the congregation rather than the denomination, but institutionalized denominations often prescribe how congregations are to be run, so local formality is a trace of denominational rules reaching down.

Table 2 reports the results, with clergy-level controls for age and gender and congregation-level controls for size, racial composition, location, and years since founding. Overall, DII aligns well with how congregations actually operate. High-polity denominations are more likely to have hosted a denominational representative. High-confession clergy affirm the return of Jesus at higher rates and vary less around their denomination’s mean. High-ordination clergy are more likely to hold seminary degrees and less likely to have been drawn from the congregation they lead. Congregations of high-DII denominations are more likely to run a written budget and to have convened their governing board.

The index should also leave an imprint on the member’s own religious life. An institution-

alized body, I argued above, supplies much of that life ready-made. Where denominations do not furnish such resources to mediate the believer's relation to God, believers sustain that relation through practices they perform themselves. Institutionalization should therefore depress private devotion and direct religious experience while leaving communal engagement intact or raising it.

I test this with four measures of private devotion from the General Social Survey (1972–2022), supplemented by the Religious Landscape Study (2007 and 2014), a nationally representative Pew survey that asks a wider range of questions about religious life and belief. For private devotion, I use frequency of Scripture reading, frequency of prayer, born-again identification, and report of a life-changing religious experience. For communal participation I use seven measures: official membership, volunteering through the church, participation in church-affiliated groups, social activities, choir, youth work, and activities beyond regular services. Each of these presupposes an organization to belong to, so the two sets separate what a believer can sustain alone from what only an organization can supply. Models control for attendance, importance of religion (in the GSS, strength of affiliation), ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, race and ethnicity, with geographic and survey-timing fixed effects and standard errors clustered on denomination.

The split is as predicted. In Panel A, every form of private devotion declines with institutionalization. In Panel B, not one form of communal participation falls: membership, volunteering, involvement in church-affiliated groups, and attendance at church social activities all rise, and the rest are indistinguishable from zero. Believers in institutionalized denominations are not less attached to their churches. By the organizational measures they are more attached. What they do less of is the religion one performs alone and holds directly.

In sum, the index tracks how denominations are governed and how believers practice. Members of institutionalized bodies hold their religion through the organization, in formal membership, committees, and volunteering under its name. Members of weakly institutionalized bodies hold it directly, in prayer, in Scripture, in a personal relationship with

Table 3: Denominational institutionalization and religious behavior

<i>Panel A: Private devotion</i>							
Dependent variable	(1) Reads scripture	(2) Reads scripture	(3) Prays	(4) Prays	(5) Born- again	(6) Born- again	(7) Rel. experience changed life
DII (0–12)	-0.0313** (0.0099)	-0.0415*** (0.0060)	-0.0136** (0.0043)	-0.0277*** (0.0041)	-0.0215*** (0.0057)	-0.0265*** (0.0044)	-0.0081* (0.0040)
Individual controls	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Fixed effects	Division + year	State + wave	Division + year	State + wave	Division + year	State + wave	Division + year
Observations	1,299	24,503	16,664	24,458	10,221	24,054	4,343
Denominations	39	75	50	75	49	75	46
Data source	GSS	RLS 2007+14	GSS	RLS 2007+14	GSS	RLS 2007+14	GSS
<i>Panel B: Congregational participation</i>							
Dependent variable	(8) Official member	(9) Volunteers through church	(10) Church-affiliated group member	(11) Social activities	(12) Choir or music	(13) Works with children	(14) Activities beyond services
DII (0–12)	0.0084*** (0.0021)	0.0205*** (0.0029)	0.0042** (0.0014)	0.0076* (0.0032)	0.0029 (0.0051)	-0.0024 (0.0045)	0.0055 (0.0056)
Individual controls	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Fixed effects	State + wave	State + wave	Division + year	State + wave	State + wave	State + wave	Division + year
Observations	24,578	11,174	9,928	11,194	11,195	11,205	8,885
Denominations	75	72	48	72	72	72	49
Data source	RLS 2007+14	RLS 2007	GSS	RLS 2007	RLS 2007	RLS 2007	GSS

Notes. $\dagger p < .10$, $* p < .05$, $** p < .01$, $*** p < .001$. U.S. Protestants. Each column is a separate OLS regression of the outcome, on its native scale with higher values indicating more of the practice, on the raw DII (0–12). Controls are attendance, strength of affiliation (GSS) or importance of religion (RLS), ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, and race and Hispanic indicators, the latter dropped where it does not vary. Standard errors are clustered on denomination. Full regression tables in Appendix Tables SI-4–SI-5.

God.

DII and Institutional Trust

I argue that members of more institutionalized churches place more trust in institutions, especially rule-making ones, both political and non-political. I focus on three groups of institutions. The first is national political institutions: the executive, Congress, and the Supreme Court, together with political parties. The second is local government: the mayor or city manager and the city council. The third is non-political bodies engaged in making and certifying knowledge: the scientific community, including modern medicine; the education system, from local schools to colleges and universities; the media; and organized religion itself. I rely on three data sources to measure institutional trust. The GSS has fielded a consistent confidence battery for five decades (1973–2022, as the 2024 release carries no detailed denomination codes). The ANES asks about fewer institutions, and many of its items are wave-specific rather than continuous, but its thermometer series covers the federal branches over the long run, and its 2024 wave asks about trust in the courts, parties, the scientific community, and the media, along with an item on colleges and universities. The CES 2016 is the only survey that asks respondents to evaluate their local political institutions and schools, and the CES 2022 adds a trust-in-federal-government item.⁷ When the same item exists in multiple surveys, I include every version, so that the findings are not artifacts of any single survey.⁸

Table 4 reports the results. Each cell is the coefficient on the DII from one model, with the outcome standardized, because the response scales differ across surveys. Every model

⁷Appendix B details how denominational DII scores are linked to respondents in each survey.

⁸I distinguish trust and confidence from approval of incumbent performance. The GSS asks whether the respondent has a great deal of confidence, only some confidence, or hardly any confidence at all in the people running each institution. The ANES asks for feeling-thermometer ratings from 0 to 100. The ANES 2024 wave asks how much the respondent trusts each institution on a four-point scale. The CES asks respondents to grade the named local offices and services from A to F. The colleges-and-universities item, approval of how they are run, is the one approval-format item retained, as the only institution-level measure of higher education in any of the four sources.

Table 4: DII and confidence in individual institutions across three surveys

	GSS confidence 1973–2022	ANES thermometer 1972–2024	ANES 2024 trust (4-pt)	CES 2016 local rating / 2022 trust
<i>1. National political branches</i>				
Executive / federal government	0.0046* (0.0017), n=20,335	0.0073* (0.0035), n=5,826	0.0100* (0.0039), n=1,603	0.0111* (0.0045), n=13,212
Congress	0.0005 (0.0015), n=20,334	0.0014 (0.0033), n=9,862	0.0056 (0.0056), n=1,606	—
U.S. Supreme Court	0.0163*** (0.0031), n=20,074	0.0074*** (0.0015), n=9,257	0.0094 (0.0067), n=1,603	—
Political parties	—	—	0.0115* (0.0047), n=1,602	—
<i>2. Local political bodies</i>				
Mayor / city manager	—	—	—	0.0064* (0.0024), n=14,146
City council	—	—	—	0.0052* (0.0023), n=14,265
<i>3. Non-political bodies</i>				
Organized religion	0.0143** (0.0049), n=20,161	—	—	—
Scientific community	0.0126** (0.0041), n=19,468	—	0.0065 (0.0051), n=1,605	—
Medicine	0.0108*** (0.0017), n=20,508	—	—	—
Press / traditional media	0.0093*** (0.0016), n=20,434	—	0.0178*** (0.0046), n=1,605	—
Television	0.0081** (0.0028), n=20,454	—	—	—
Education	0.0079** (0.0029), n=20,450	—	—	—
Colleges and universities	—	—	0.0134** (0.0048), n=1,763	—
Local schools	—	—	—	0.0085** (0.0030), n=15,330

Notes. [†] $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. U.S. Protestants. Every cell is the coefficient on the raw DII (0–12) with the outcome standardized, so cells are comparable as SD-per-DII-point. All models control for attendance, ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, race, and family income, with survey-year and state fixed effects (census division in the GSS, whose public release carries no state). Standard errors are clustered on the adult denomination. Full regression tables in Appendix Tables SI-6 and SI-7–SI-9.

controls for race, sex, age, education, family income, ideology, partisanship, and religious attendance, with geographic fixed effects, survey-year fixed effects where more than one wave enters, and standard errors clustered on denomination. The results are consistent across the three groups of institutions. Members of highly institutionalized churches have more confidence in organized religion, and they extend that confidence to secular institutions: the federal executive, the Supreme Court,⁹ political parties, the mayor and the city council, the press, the scientific community and medicine, and the education system from local schools through colleges and universities. The magnitudes are substantively meaningful. In the GSS models, the difference between a Southern Baptist and a Missouri Synod Lutheran, seven points on the index, moves confidence in the Supreme Court by about a tenth of a standard deviation, an effect slightly larger than that of one unit increase in the five-category education scale, roughly the distance from a high school graduate to a junior college degree, and moves confidence in the scientific community by about two-thirds as much. Congress is the one institution whose coefficient never separates from zero on any of the three trust measures that carry it. One tentative reading is that Congress is judged by who controls it at the moment rather than as a standing institution.

One threat to a causal interpretation of the findings is sorting into denominations. As recent work has pointed out, the causal arrow between religion and political attitudes runs both ways: religion not only shapes political attitudes but is itself sometimes the product of political views (Margolis, 2018*a,b*; Patrikios, 2008; Putnam and Campbell, 2010; Campbell et al., 2018). It is therefore possible that people who already trust institutions select into churches that run on credentials and procedure, while people with a more suspicious attitude toward institutional authority go to less institutionalized churches.

To address self-selection into denominations, I use the denomination in which the respondent was raised at age 16 as an instrument for the adult DII, since that choice was made by

⁹In the ANES 2024 wave, the standardized judiciary coefficient (0.0094) lies between the GSS estimate (0.0163) and the ANES thermometer estimate (0.0074), so the point estimate is in line with the other two sources. But the module was fielded in a single wave, and at that sample size ($n = 1,603$) the coefficient cannot be separated from zero.

the parents rather than by the respondent. The strategy is available only for the GSS, which has carried the childhood-denomination item on a consistent frame for five decades, and not for the ANES or the CES, which do not ask the question. The estimate is informative about selection to the extent that the childhood denomination is unrelated to adult institutional trust except through the adult denomination. The main threat to that condition is the parents themselves, whose denominations are shaped in part by their education, class, and income, the same backgrounds that shape their own institutional trust, and those attitudes can pass to their children. In a stricter specification I therefore add the full childhood-background battery: parental education, relative family income at 16, father’s occupational prestige, and the type of place (urban or rural) and census division of upbringing. The battery closes the observable socioeconomic route but not the others, such as the church’s influence on parenting at home or the community of upbringing that a denomination stands for. The instrumented estimates are therefore evidence against the specific concern of adult selection into denominations rather than estimates of the causal effect.

Table 5 compares the OLS and instrumental-variable estimates. Each cell reports the DII coefficient from one model. Column 1 gives the OLS estimate with the controls and fixed effects of Table 4, column 2 applies the instrumental-variable strategy, and column 3 adds strict controls for family background. All three columns are estimated on the same sample for each outcome, namely respondents with no missing value on any control variable, including the background battery. Differences across columns therefore cannot be produced by differences in sample. That sample is smaller than in Table 4 because father’s occupational prestige and family income at 16 are frequently missing. Standard errors are clustered on adult denomination in column 1 and on childhood denomination, the level at which the instrument varies, in columns 2 and 3.

The instrumented estimates tell the same story as the OLS estimates. If adults sorted into denominations on their prior trust in institutions, the IV estimates would shrink across the board. Across institutions the coefficients move little when the DII is instrumented,

Table 5: Childhood-DII instrumental-variables estimates (GSS)

Dependent variable	OLS	2SLS (naive)	2SLS + full childhood background battery	F	F (bg)	N
<i>Confidence in... (1-3, higher = more confidence)</i>						
Executive branch	0.0045*** (0.0013)	0.0035 [†] (0.0017)	0.0025 (0.0019)	1175	1214	11,809
Congress	0.0024 [†] (0.0012)	-0.0012 (0.0023)	-0.0008 (0.0025)	1142	1184	11,810
U.S. Supreme Court	0.0108*** (0.0022)	0.0111*** (0.0029)	0.0097*** (0.0027)	1123	1163	11,690
Organized religion	0.0097** (0.0033)	0.0092** (0.0032)	0.0091* (0.0035)	1118	1171	11,680
Scientific community	0.0084*** (0.0022)	0.0085** (0.0027)	0.0058* (0.0023)	1109	1132	11,342
Medicine	0.0070*** (0.0009)	0.0100*** (0.0019)	0.0093*** (0.0018)	1137	1192	11,872
Education	0.0063** (0.0022)	0.0034 [†] (0.0019)	0.0043* (0.0021)	1157	1198	11,856
Press	0.0056*** (0.0014)	0.0042 (0.0027)	0.0032 (0.0026)	1193	1253	11,837
Television	0.0050** (0.0017)	0.0051* (0.0025)	0.0056* (0.0023)	1162	1207	11,839

Notes. [†] $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. U.S. Protestants raised Protestant, GSS 1973–2022. The instrument is the DII of the denomination in which the respondent was raised at age 16. All three columns control for attendance, ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, race, and log real family income, with census-division and survey-year fixed effects. The third column adds the childhood-background battery, parental education, relative family income at 16, father’s occupational prestige, and type of place lived in at 16, with fixed effects for the census division of upbringing. All three columns are estimated on the same complete-case sample, so nothing in a row moves because of who is in the sample. F and F(bg) are the cluster-robust first-stage F statistics on the excluded instrument. Standard errors are clustered on the childhood denomination, the level at which the instrument varies, in the 2SLS columns, and on the adult denomination in the OLS column. Full regression tables in Appendix Tables SI-10–SI-12.

and where they do move there is no general attenuation: medicine rises from 0.0070 to 0.0100, while the Supreme Court, organized religion, and television stay essentially where they were. Confidence in the scientific community is unchanged under the instrument alone and attenuates by about a third once the background battery enters, but remains significant. The press and the executive branch are the exceptions. Both point estimates fall and neither can be separated from zero under the instrument, but the standard errors roughly double at the same time, so these estimates cannot be distinguished from their OLS counterparts either. Congress, marginal in the OLS to begin with, falls to zero under the instrument, consistent with its null throughout Table 4.

DII and Populism

I next move from institutional trust to a related set of outcomes: anti-establishment populist sentiments. Scholarship has linked anti-institutional attitudes to populist sentiment (Rooduijn, 2018; Uscinski et al., 2021), a disposition that divides the world between "the people" and "the elite" and depicts the elite as corrupt, self-serving, and alienated from those it claims to serve (Mudde, 2004; Müller, 2016). The literature on populism has traditionally centered on attitudes toward politicians, but recent work has observed that anti-establishment sentiment is not confined to those who hold political power. It extends to those who control knowledge production: experts (Oliver and Rahn, 2016; Merkley, 2020). I therefore move from confidence in specific institutions to evaluations of the government as a whole and of elites as a class, including both politicians and experts.

I turn to the ANES to test the association between the DII and populist attitudes. The first battery, in Panel A, concerns the government as a whole and the officials who run it: whether hardly any officials are crooked, whether the government is run for the benefit of all or by a few big interests, whether it can be trusted to do what is right, and whether it wastes tax money. These are the standard ANES trust-in-government items, carried in

the cumulative file for five decades. Estimation begins in 1972, the first year the ANES asked respondents to place themselves on an ideology scale. Two of the four items were retired after 2012, so Panel A mixes series running to 2012 with series running to 2024. The second battery, in Panel B, asks about politicians as a class. It was fielded in 2016 and 2020, which I pool. The items cover whether the people rather than politicians should decide policy, whether politicians care what people like the respondent think, whether politicians are the main problem in the country, whether they serve only the rich and powerful, whether compromise amounts to selling out, and whether most politicians can be trusted. The final two items, in Panel C, concern experts rather than government or politicians: whether the respondent trusts experts more than ordinary people, and whether ordinary people need the help of experts. Both were fielded in 2020.

Table 6 reports the results, and the three panels tell one story: members of more institutionalized denominations extend more credit to the establishment. In Panel A all four coefficients are positive and significant. In Panel B, high-DII respondents are less likely to endorse the populist statements, rejecting the claims that politicians do not care what people like them think and that compromise amounts to selling out, and they are more likely to agree that most politicians can be trusted, the one item in the battery whose endorsement runs against the populist position. Panel C extends the disposition from political to epistemic authority: the same respondents trust experts over ordinary people, and the second expert item points the same way but does not separate from zero. Institutionalization does not merely predict confidence in particular institutions. It predicts rejection of the populist frame itself, whether the elite in question holds office or holds knowledge.

The literature often links the rise of right-wing populism to nativism or racism (Mutz, 2018a; Berman, 2021; Mudde, 2007). The disposition the DII produces, however, does not extend to either. Across the thirteen nativism and racial-resentment items the CES carries, no coefficient is significant in the exclusionary direction, and the two that reach significance run the other way (Appendix Table SI-23). Low institutionalization produces a disposition

Table 6: DII and populist sentiment about politicians and government (ANES)

Dependent variable	Coef.	(SE)	N	Denoms.	Years
<i>A. Officials and elite capture (cumulative file; higher = the trusting response)</i>					
Hardly any officials are crooked (1–3)	0.0072***	(0.0016)	11,509	63	1972–2012
Government run for the benefit of all (0/1)	0.0039***	(0.0008)	15,695	67	1972–2024
Trusts government to do what is right (1–4)	0.0053*	(0.0023)	11,248	61	1972–2012
Government does not waste tax money (1–3)	0.0047***	(0.0008)	16,287	68	1972–2024
<i>B. The people-vs-politicians battery (2016 + 2020 pooled; higher = agrees)</i>					
People, not politicians, should decide policy (1–5)	-0.0087	(0.0052)	4,006	52	2016+2020
Most politicians do not care about the people (1–5)	-0.0108**	(0.0034)	4,010	52	2016+2020
Politicians are the main problem in the U.S. (1–5)	0.0009	(0.0054)	4,010	52	2016+2020
Politicians care only about the rich and powerful (1–5)	-0.0105	(0.0063)	4,010	52	2016+2020
Compromise in politics is selling out (1–5)	-0.0163**	(0.0060)	4,010	52	2016+2020
Most politicians are trustworthy (1–5)	0.0109***	(0.0028)	4,010	52	2016+2020
<i>C. Experts versus the people (2020; higher = defers to experts)</i>					
Trusts experts more than ordinary people (1–5)	0.0061*	(0.0030)	2,722	48	2020
Ordinary people need experts’ help (1–5)	0.0066	(0.0040)	2,724	48	2020

Notes. [†] $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. U.S. Protestants. Each row reports the coefficient on the DII (0–12) from a separate OLS regression, with the outcome on its native scale. Controls are attendance, ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, race, and family income, with survey-year and state fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered on the denomination. Full regression tables in Appendix Tables SI-13 and SI-14.

toward institutional authority, not the full populist package.

From Attitudes to Behavior: County-Level Evidence

Finally, I examine whether the institutional trust and pro-establishment attitudes of high-DII members stop at the survey or carry into behavior. Here I leave individual survey data for county-level evidence.

The first behavioral outcome is the vote. A large literature reads Trump’s rise as an expression of anti-institutional and anti-establishment sentiment (Mutz, 2018*b*; Sides, Tesler and Vavreck, 2018). The general-election vote, however, is a poor measure of that sentiment. Most voters voted the party line, and a Trump ballot cannot distinguish those who supported him because of his break with the establishment from those who supported him despite it. I therefore focus on the 2016 Republican primary, where party is held constant and the anti-establishment candidate ran against copartisan alternatives drawn from the party

establishment. A county’s Trump share in that contest measures the willingness of Republican voters to reject their own party’s establishment (MacWilliams, 2016; Rothwell and Diego-Rosell, 2016; Monnat and Brown, 2017; Bursztyn, Egorov and Fiorin, 2020).

The second outcome is the COVID-19 vaccination rate. Populism is not confined to the political domain, and the disposition that rejects the political class often extends to experts. During the pandemic, suspicion of scientific consensus and of public health expertise translated into refusal of a vaccine that medical authority endorsed (Kennedy, 2019; Mede and Schäfer, 2020), a costly act that carried real risk to the refuser’s own health.

I use county-level returns from the 2016 Republican presidential primary, compiled from CNN’s reported results (Hamner, 2016), and the county full-vaccination rate as of December 2021, compiled by the Bansal Lab from CDC county data and state health-department dashboards (Tiu et al., 2022).¹⁰ I then use the 2010 U.S. Religion Census (Grammich, 2012), which reports congregations and adherents by county for the 85 Protestant bodies, to construct a county-level Protestant DII: the adherent-weighted mean of the DII scores of the denominations present in the county, so a county of Episcopalians and Missouri Synod Lutherans scores high and a county of independent Baptist and nondenominational congregations scores low.

The baseline specification, columns 1 and 4 of Table 7, includes a battery of demographic controls from the U.S. Census Bureau (2026) and the MIT Election Data and Science Lab (2018): the shares white, Hispanic, foreign born, without a four-year degree, below the poverty line, unemployed, rural, and over 65, log median household income, and log population density, together with the county’s Protestant and Catholic adherence rates from the Religion Census (Grammich, 2012). It also includes total frontier experience (Bazzi, Fiszbein and Gebresilasse, 2020) and state fixed effects. Frontier individualism may produce populism directly, and it may also have produced the religious ecology in which low-DII Protestantism thrives, since

¹⁰The primary returns cover 39 states. The rest held no primary vote, did not report results by county, or reported by town. The vaccination rate is each county’s last report on or before December 31, 2021, when every adult had been eligible for eight months.

Table 7: County religious composition, the 2016 primary, and vaccination

	Trump 2016 GOP- primary share (pp)			Full vaccination rate, Dec. 2021 (pp)		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
County DII (index points)	-0.6799*** (0.1771)	-0.5870** (0.1832)	-0.5754** (0.1808)	0.7713** (0.2497)	0.9766*** (0.2281)	0.7448** (0.2301)
% Protestant adherents	-0.0980*** (0.0131)	-0.0855*** (0.0144)	-0.0876*** (0.0157)	-0.0371† (0.0208)	-0.0149 (0.0255)	0.0246 (0.0266)
% Catholic adherents	0.0344† (0.0201)	0.0021 (0.0207)	0.0026 (0.0208)	0.0466† (0.0257)	0.0414 (0.0299)	0.0586* (0.0230)
% white	0.0308 (0.0242)	0.0334 (0.0275)	0.0189 (0.0274)	-0.2047*** (0.0236)	-0.2086*** (0.0317)	0.1384** (0.0438)
% Hispanic	-0.1216*** (0.0274)	-0.1072*** (0.0299)	-0.1098** (0.0318)	0.0988** (0.0304)	0.1117** (0.0344)	0.1800*** (0.0365)
% foreign born	0.2292* (0.0987)	0.2137† (0.1068)	0.2057† (0.1019)	-0.1098† (0.0560)	-0.1197* (0.0541)	0.0614 (0.0622)
% non-college	0.3880*** (0.0442)	0.3739*** (0.0454)	0.3661*** (0.0430)	-0.5451*** (0.0759)	-0.5442*** (0.0701)	-0.1551*** (0.0400)
Log median income	-0.9538 (1.8902)	-2.0450 (1.6663)	-2.2630 (1.7789)	-0.7874 (2.2408)	-0.8175 (2.3164)	4.3150* (1.9137)
% below poverty	0.0879* (0.0393)	0.0631† (0.0331)	0.0657† (0.0354)	-0.1838* (0.0909)	-0.1966* (0.0890)	-0.1974* (0.0875)
% unemployed	0.3059*** (0.0806)	0.2279** (0.0827)	0.2282** (0.0836)	0.2397† (0.1210)	0.1716 (0.1126)	0.1506 (0.1088)
% rural	-0.0168 (0.0102)	-0.0063 (0.0099)	-0.0056 (0.0100)	0.0091 (0.0167)	0.0120 (0.0148)	-0.0008 (0.0089)
% age 65+	0.3740*** (0.0633)	0.3524*** (0.0624)	0.3599*** (0.0595)	0.4927*** (0.0615)	0.4842*** (0.0584)	0.3735*** (0.0668)
Log population density	-0.6610* (0.2865)	-0.8043* (0.3023)	-0.7519* (0.3312)	1.6829** (0.5003)	1.6199*** (0.4263)	0.1365 (0.2373)
Romney 2012 vote share	—	—	0.0225 (0.0448)	—	—	—
Trump 2020 vote share	—	—	—	—	—	-0.4874*** (0.0567)
Frontier TFE (decades)	-0.1895 (0.2188)	-0.1947 (0.1968)	-0.2001 (0.2033)	0.1240 (0.1851)	0.0673 (0.1610)	0.1020 (0.1277)
Nine European-ancestry shares	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Prior-vote baseline	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes
State fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	2,732	2,732	2,732	3,079	3,079	3,079
States (clusters)	43	43	43	44	44	44
DV mean	47.0	47.0	47.0	47.7	47.7	47.7
DV SD	15.7	15.7	15.7	12.5	12.5	12.5

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Columns 2, 3, 5, and 6 add nine European-ancestry shares, not shown. Columns 3 and 6 add the county's prior Republican vote share: the Romney 2012 general-election share for the primary outcome and the Trump 2020 share for the vaccination outcome. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered by state.

the frontier is where the itinerant preachers of the upstart denominations found their audience (Hatch, 1989; Finke and Stark, 2005). Columns 2 and 5 add nine European-ancestry shares from the Census Bureau, because a county’s denominational composition is in part a residue of where immigrant groups settled: Germans and Scandinavians went to the Lutheran synods, the Dutch to the Reformed churches, and the Scots-Irish to Presbyterianism. Settlement of this kind leaves its own imprint on political culture (Fischer, 1989; Lieske, 1993; Rice and Feldman, 1997; Jaworski and Kimbrough, 2026), so the ancestry shares absorb what the county DII would otherwise pick up from ethnic origin. Columns 3 and 6 add the county’s prior Republican vote share, the Romney 2012 general-election share for the primary vote share and Trump 2020 share for the vaccination rate.

A county whose Protestant adherents belong to more institutionalized bodies gave a smaller share of its Republican primary vote to Trump and had vaccinated more of its residents by December 2021. A one-standard-deviation difference in the county DII, 1.8 points, implies 1.0 percentage points in the Trump vote and 1.3 percentage points in the vaccination rate in columns 3 and 6, the most stringent specifications, which include the prior Republican vote share. What institutionalized religious life shapes is not only expressed attitudes but revealed preferences.

Robustness Checks and Additional Analysis

I conduct several additional analyses. First, if members learn institutional trust inside institutionalized churches, the association should be strongest for the members most exposed to church life, the most frequent church attendees. I interact the DII with church attendance, which is used as a control in the main specification, in every individual-level model of Tables 4 and 6, with the outcome and attendance standardized, and report the full grid in Appendix Tables SI-20 and SI-21. For confidence in specific institutions the dose is strong and consistent: seven of the nine GSS interactions are positive and significant. For the populist battery the

evidence is thinner: the interactions sit near zero with none significant. One reading of the contrast is that participation transmits a template for judging institutional authority rather than an affect toward politicians as a class, so the judgments deepen with exposure while the sentiment does not.

Furthermore, Appendix E extends the analysis to Catholics, a group whose historical relationship with American institutions was complicated by societal and institutional discrimination and by direct conflict between secular and religious authority, especially before Vatican II, when the Church had not yet accepted the separation of church and state (McGreevy, 2003; Casanova, 1994). The results show a trust deficit among older cohorts, who carried the memory of exclusion, that narrows or reverses among younger generations. One exception is organized religion, where the gap between younger Catholics and Protestants is larger, potentially reflecting exposure to the abuse scandals of the Catholic Church in recent decades.

One potential challenge is that the DII records only the difference between theologically conservative and liberal Protestants, the division the literature codes as evangelical versus mainline (Steensland et al., 2000). Evangelical bodies do lean toward the low-institutional end and mainline bodies toward the high, but each camp spans the range. The evangelical camp holds confessional denominations descended from the Reformation, such as the Lutheran Church–Missouri Synod and the Presbyterian Church in America, alongside congregationally governed revivalist bodies, such as the Southern Baptists. The mainline camp runs from congregational bodies, such as the Disciples and the United Church of Christ, to the most hierarchical Protestant churches in the country, the Episcopalians and the United Methodists. To separate the two, I control for theological conservatism at the individual level, where the respondent’s own theology can be measured directly. I rerun every individual-level model of Tables 4 and 6 controlling for born-again self-identification, an individual-level operationalization of evangelicalism that performs comparably to the denominational coding (Burge and Lewis, 2018), for biblical literalism, the item asking whether the Bible is to be taken as true word for word, which has divided theological liberals from conservatives since

the fundamentalist controversy, and for the two together (Appendix Tables SI-15, SI-16, and SI-17).¹¹ The results barely move, and nearly every coefficient that is significant in the main tables survives.

Furthermore, the denomination-level evangelical-mainline coding, RelTrad, bundles theological conservatism with institutional form, since it grounds the distinction in part on a denomination's origin in a church-like or a sect-like movement (Steensland et al., 2000, 293–297), a distinction that turns on organizational form. Conditioning on it would fold the treatment into the control. The point is therefore not that the divide the literature has identified does not matter. Institutionalization is a constituent of that divide, an organizational channel running beneath the theological one, and the two have been conflated because the standard classification measures them together.

I conduct two further sensitivity checks. First, not every respondent can be matched to an exact denominational body. Some report only a denominational family, Lutheran, Pentecostal, or Holiness, without naming the body, and this is especially common in the earlier GSS waves, whose denomination codes are coarser. Rather than discard these respondents, I assign them the score of their family's largest body, and the appendix describes the assignment in full. As a check, I re-estimate the individual-level models on the years in which the surveys probe specific denominational bodies, 1984 and later in the GSS and 1990 and later in the ANES, a restriction defined by the survey's coding rather than by the respondents' answers. The estimates are unchanged or slightly stronger (Appendix Table SI-18).

Second, I exclude the nondenominational churches, a heterogeneous set of congregations that sits at the bottom of the index. Because these churches anchor the low end, the results could in principle reflect a single contrast between nondenominational and denominational Protestantism rather than a gradient running across denominations. Dropping the cell leaves the main results intact (Appendix Table SI-19). The headline coefficients grow slightly rather than shrink, and the only casualties are a few cells that lose precision as the sample thins.

¹¹The CES carries no literalism item, so its cells are checked against born-again identification alone.

Conclusion

This paper examines how the organization of religious authority in a church shapes its members' political attitudes and behavior. In denominations where authority is mediated by written constitutions, binding confessions, ordination credentials, and disciplinary machinery, members extend more trust to secular institutions, from the federal executive and the Supreme Court to local government, the scientific community, and medicine. They are less likely to hold populist anti-establishment sentiments, whether the elite in question holds office or holds knowledge. Using aggregate-level data, I show that counties whose Protestants belong to more institutionalized bodies gave a smaller share of their 2016 Republican primary vote to the anti-establishment candidate and had higher vaccination rates during the COVID-19 pandemic.

Two directions are left for future work. First, a long literature holds that the form of associational life shapes general social trust, not only trust in institutions (Putnam, Leonardi and Nanetti, 1993; Stolle and Rochon, 1998). Whether the disposition documented here extends from institutions to strangers is the natural next question. Second, the paper measures one religious family in one country. Across the world's religious traditions, the organization of religious authority varies far more widely than it does within American Protestantism. Future work that applies the conceptual and coding scheme of this project across traditions would turn a claim about American Protestants into a claim about religion and institutional life in general.

The finding carries an important implication. The American religious landscape has been moving toward de-institutionalization: institutionalized denominations, both mainline and conservative, have contracted for two generations, while the nondenominational and loosely affiliated congregations have grown (Chaves, 2017). If church life trains dispositions toward institutional authority, this shift in the religious field has been quietly withdrawing one of the schools in which such dispositions formed.

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Supplementary Materials

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A The Denominational Institutionalization Index

A.1 Coding of Each Denomination

Table SI-1: The coded ledger: all 124 denominations

Denomination	A	B	C	D	DII
Christian Reformed Church	2	3	3	3	11
Episcopal Church in the USA	3	2	3	3	11
Reformed Presbyterian Church of North America	2	3	3	3	11
Seventh-day Adventist	3	2	3	3	11
United Methodist Church	3	2	3	3	11
Associate Reformed Presbyterian	2	3	3	2	10
Church of God (Cleveland TN)	3	2	2	3	10
Church of the United Brethren in Christ	3	2	3	2	10
Evangelical Lutheran Synod	1	3	3	3	10
Evangelical Presbyterian Church	2	2	3	3	10
Heritage Reformed Congregations	2	3	3	2	10
Lutheran Church Missouri Synod	1	3	3	3	10
Presbyterian Church in America	2	3	3	2	10
Presbyterian Church USA	2	2	3	3	10
Protestant Reformed Churches in America	2	3	3	2	10
Reformed Church in America	2	3	2	3	10
Reformed Church in the United States	2	3	3	2	10
Salvation Army	3	3	2	2	10
Wisconsin Evangelical Lutheran Synod	1	3	3	3	10
African Methodist Episcopal	3	1	3	2	9
AME Zion	3	1	3	2	9
Anglican Church (US respondents mostly ACNA/continuing)	3	2	2	2	9
Bible Presbyterian Church	1	3	3	2	9
Christian and Missionary Alliance	3	2	2	2	9
Christian Methodist Episcopal	3	1	3	2	9
Church of God in Christ	3	2	2	2	9
Church of God of Prophecy	3	2	2	2	9
Church of the Lutheran Confession	1	3	3	2	9
Evangelical Congregational Church	3	2	2	2	9
Evangelical Lutheran Church in America	2	2	3	2	9
Foursquare Gospel	3	2	2	2	9
Free Methodist (holiness family entry)	3	2	2	2	9
Free Methodist Church	3	2	2	2	9
Moravian Church in America	2	2	3	2	9
Orthodox Presbyterian Church	2	2	3	2	9
Pentecostal Holiness (IPHC)	3	2	2	2	9
Worldwide Church of God (Grace Communion)	3	2	1	3	9
Anglican Orthodox Church	3	2	2	1	8
Assemblies of God	1	2	2	3	8
Bible Fellowship Church	2	2	2	2	8
Church of the Nazarene	2	2	2	2	8
Churches of God, General Conference	2	2	2	2	8
Cumberland Presbyterian	2	2	2	2	8
Evangelical Covenant Church	1	2	2	3	8
Evangelical Methodist Church	2	2	2	2	8
Latvian Evangelical Lutheran Church in America	2	2	2	2	8
Open Bible Standard Churches	2	2	2	2	8
Pentecostal Church of God	2	2	2	2	8
Reformed Mennonite Church	2	2	1	3	8

continued on next page

Table SI-1 (continued)

Denomination	A	B	C	D	DII
The Missionary Church	2	2	2	2	8
Wesleyan Church	2	2	2	2	8
Apostolic Faith Mission of Portland OR	3	2	1	1	7
Brethren in Christ Church	2	2	2	1	7
Church of God (Anderson IN)	1	2	2	2	7
Church of the Lutheran Brethren of America	1	2	2	2	7
Congregational Holiness Church	2	2	1	2	7
Congregational Methodist Church	1	2	2	2	7
Disciples of Christ	1	2	2	2	7
Evangelical Free Church of America	1	2	2	2	7
Evangelical Friends Church International	2	2	1	2	7
Fellowship of Evangelical Churches	1	2	2	2	7
Independent Methodist	1	2	2	2	7
Mennonite Church USA	1	1	2	3	7
North American Baptist Conference	1	2	2	2	7
United Church of Christ	1	2	2	2	7
Allegheny Wesleyan Methodist Connection	2	2	1	1	6
American Baptist Churches USA	1	2	2	1	6
Apostolic Christian	1	2	2	1	6
Church of the Brethren	2	0	2	2	6
Conservative Congregational Christian Conference	1	2	1	2	6
Convention of Original Free Will Baptists	1	2	1	2	6
Fellowship of Evangelical Bible Churches	1	2	1	2	6
Lutheran Congregations in Mission for Christ	1	2	1	2	6
Primitive Methodist Church in the USA	2	2	1	1	6
Seventh Day Baptist General Conference	1	2	1	2	6
Sovereign Grace Churches	2	1	2	1	6
United Pentecostal Church International	1	2	1	2	6
Assembly of Christian Churches	1	1	1	2	5
Association of Free Lutheran Congregations	1	2	1	1	5
Central Yearly Meeting of Friends	2	1	1	1	5
Free Will Baptist	1	1	1	2	5
Friends United Meeting	2	1	1	1	5
International Pentecostal Church of Christ	1	2	1	1	5
Pillar of Fire	3	1	1	0	5
Apostolic Lutheran Church in America	1	1	1	1	4
Charis Fellowship (Fellowship of Grace Brethren Churches)	1	1	1	1	4
Church of God of the Apostolic Faith	2	1	1	0	4
Full Gospel Baptist Church Fellowship	1	1	1	1	4
Vineyard USA	1	2	1	0	4
Baptist Bible Fellowship International	0	2	1	0	3
Baptist General Conference (Converge)	1	1	1	0	3
Baptist Missionary Association	1	1	1	0	3
Calvary Chapel Association	1	1	1	0	3
Conservative Yearly Meetings of Friends	2	0	0	1	3
General Association of Regular Baptists	1	1	1	0	3
National Baptist Convention	1	1	1	0	3
National Baptist Convention of America	1	1	1	0	3
National Missionary Baptist Convention	1	1	1	0	3
Progressive National Baptist Convention	1	1	1	0	3

continued on next page

Table SI-1 (continued)

Denomination	A	B	C	D	DII
Schwenkfelder Church	1	1	1	0	3
Southern Baptist Convention	1	1	1	0	3
Advent Christian Church	0	1	1	0	2
American Baptist Association	0	1	1	0	2
Church of God General Conference	0	1	1	0	2
Conservative Baptist Association	0	1	1	0	2
Friends General Conference	2	0	0	0	2
Independent Baptist	0	1	1	0	2
Independent Presbyterian	0	1	1	0	2
Independent Yearly Meetings of Friends	2	0	0	0	2
Midwest Congregational Christian Fellowship	0	1	1	0	2
National Association of Congregational Christian Churches	1	0	1	0	2
Primitive Baptist	0	1	1	0	2
Reformed / Calvinist Baptist	0	1	1	0	2
Christian Churches and Churches of Christ	0	0	1	0	1
Congregational Christian Churches, Additional	0	0	1	0	1
Cooperative Baptist Fellowship	0	0	1	0	1
Independent Congregational Church	0	0	1	0	1
Plymouth Brethren (Christian/Open Brethren)	0	1	0	0	1
Church of Christ	0	0	0	0	0
Community church	0	0	0	0	0
Interdenominational	0	0	0	0	0
Nondenominational charismatic	0	0	0	0	0
Nondenominational evangelical	0	0	0	0	0
Nondenominational fundamentalist	0	0	0	0	0

Notes. A = polity, B = confessional subscription, C = ordination threshold, D = disciplinary machinery, each 0–3. DII is the unweighted sum. Bodies are sorted by DII. Sources and the justification for every coding decision are released with the dataset.

B Data and Measurement

B.1 Data Sources

Table SI-2: Data sources

Source	Waves used	Denomination frame	Role	Coverage	Fallback
<i>Individual-level surveys</i>					
General Social Survey	1972–2022	detailed codes (DENOM, OTHER)	trust, behaviour, IV	88.0%	53.5%
ANES cumulative file	1972–2024	detailed codes 1990+, family frame before	trust, populism	80.6%	52.0%
ANES time series	2016, 2020, 2024	wave denomination codes	trust, populism, experts	99.5%	15.7%
Cooperative Election Study	2016, 2022	religpew two-step	local government, robustness	94.2 / 93.5%	1.0 / 0.4%
Pew Religious Landscape Study	2007, 2014	detailed codes	religious behaviour	79.6 / 78.9%	15.3 / 16.6%
<i>Validation and aggregate sources</i>					
National Congregations Study	1998–2019 (cumulative)	denomination reported by informant	validation	n/a	n/a
Cooperative Clergy Study Project	2000, 2017	sampled by denomination	validation	n/a	n/a
U.S. Religion Census	2010	85 reporting bodies	county DII	98.8%	n/a
County outcomes	2016 primary; CDC series to Dec. 2021	—	behaviour	n/a	n/a

Notes. Coverage is the share of self-reported Protestants routed to one of the 124 coded bodies. Fallback is the share of routed respondents assigned by family fallback rather than an exact body match, described in Appendix B.2. For the GSS, the ANES cumulative file, and the CES 2022 the figures come from the coverage audit (86.1 percent pooled coverage, with 53.9 percent of coded respondents matching an exact body, 42.3 percent assigned by family fallback, and 3.8 percent in within-family residual categories). The remaining figures are computed by the same rules: ANES time series pooled over the three waves, CES and RLS shown per wave. The high ANES time-series coverage reflects a code frame the crosswalk covers in full. The low ANES cumulative figure reflects the coarse family frame of the 1960–1988 waves. For the U.S. Religion Census, coverage is the share of Protestant adherents belonging to the 85 mapped bodies. Cells marked n/a are sources where the concept does not apply: the NCS records the denomination directly from the congregation’s informant, the CCSP samples pastors by denomination, and the county outcome series carry no denomination at all.

B.2 Linking Respondents to the Ledger

Each survey asks its own denomination question, and each is routed to the coding ledger through a survey-specific crosswalk. The routing has two steps. Where the respondent names a specific body, the response matches that body directly. Exact matches account for 53.9 percent of coded respondents across the three audited frames, and for nearly all coded

respondents in the CES, whose two-step question first asks the denominational family and then the specific body within it.

Where the response identifies only a family, the respondent is assigned the family's largest body by adherents, with race taken into account where a family bundles historically white and historically Black bodies. A Baptist without a named convention scores as the Southern Baptist Convention, a Methodist as the United Methodist Church, a Lutheran as the Evangelical Lutheran Church in America, a Presbyterian as the Presbyterian Church (U.S.A.), and a nondenominational identifier enters at zero. A Black respondent goes instead to the largest body of the family's Black wing, the National Baptist Convention for Baptists and the African Methodist Episcopal Church for Methodists, following Steensland et al. (2000). For Baptists the reassignment changes the cluster rather than the score, as both conventions sit at three on the index. The fallback carries 53.5 percent of coded GSS respondents and 52.0 percent of the ANES cumulative file, where the 1960–1988 waves recorded only the family, against roughly 16 percent in the recent ANES waves and the RLS and about 1 percent in the CES. Because the fill compresses variation, it attenuates the estimates toward zero, and the coefficients reported in the paper are conservative on this account.

C Full Regression Tables

C.1 Validation: DII, Church Governance, and Religious Life

Table SI-3: Validation of the dimension scores: full specifications

Dependent variable	A		B		C		DII	
	(1) Denom. representative hosted	(2) Agrees <i>Jesus</i> <i>will return</i>	(3) SD of agreement (denom. level)	(4) Seminary graduate (informant)	(5) Seminary graduate (self-report)	(6) Leader from inside congr.	(7) Written budget	(8) Board met
Institutionalization score (raw)	0.1324*** (0.0290)	0.2026* (0.0927)	-0.2055* (0.0959)	0.0843*** (0.0071)	0.1606** (0.0475)	-0.0727*** (0.0123)	0.0125** (0.0033)	0.0095*** (0.0023)
Log adult size / members	0.0222† (0.0124)	-0.1198*** (0.0249)	—	0.0573*** (0.0086)	0.0821* (0.0264)	-0.0038 (0.0088)	0.0612*** (0.0091)	0.0295† (0.0153)
White share of congregation	-0.0010 (0.0006)	—	—	0.0004 (0.0004)	—	-0.0014*** (0.0003)	0.0010*** (0.0002)	0.0003 (0.0003)
Congregation age (years)	0.0006* (0.0002)	—	—	0.0008* (0.0004)	—	-0.0003 (0.0003)	0.0002* (0.0001)	-0.0002 (0.0001)
Urban location	—	-0.1191** (0.0377)	—	—	0.0678* (0.0267)	—	—	—
Clergy female	—	-0.4835** (0.1216)	—	—	0.0441 (0.0278)	—	—	—
Clergy age (years)	—	-0.0095*** (0.0019)	—	—	-0.0025** (0.0007)	—	—	—
Fixed effects	Division + year	Year	None	Division + year	State + year	Division + year	Division + year	Division + year
Observations	2,505	6,652	17	1,237	2,366	1,241	2,494	626
Denominations (clusters)	17	17	17	17	10	17	17	17
DV mean	0.532	4.501	0.716	0.808	0.848	0.187	0.897	0.941
DV SD	0.499	0.897	0.351	0.394	0.359	0.390	0.305	0.236
Data source	NCS	CCSP 2000	CCSP 2000	NCS	CCSP 2017	NCS	NCS	NCS

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. The regressor in each column is the raw score for the dimension in the column group: A (polity, 0–3), B (confessional binding, 0–3), C (ordination threshold, 0–3), or the full DII (0–12) in columns (7)–(8), which are reported as associations with internal formalisation rather than validation, both items being amendable by the congregation itself. NCS models (1, 4, 6, 7, 8) are estimated on congregations with controls for log adult participants, white share, and years since founding, and region and survey-year fixed effects. CCSP models (2, 5) are estimated on individual clergy with controls for log adult members, urban location (community of 100,000 or more, or its suburb), clergy gender, and clergy age, neither wave asking when the congregation was founded; column (5) uses the 2017 wave, the only one carrying a geographic identifier, with state fixed effects; columns (2) and (3) use the 2000 wave, the only one carrying the belief battery. The outcome in column (2) is agreement with the proposition that Jesus will return to earth one day, on the five-point agree–disagree scale reversed so that higher values indicate more agreement. It is the one item in the CCSP doctrinal battery affirmed in the ecumenical creeds and in every confessional standard the second dimension codes; the battery’s remaining doctrinal items state positions in the fundamentalist–modernist controversy, biblical inerrancy chief among them, and so measure theological conservatism rather than confessional subscription, while the one other creedal-sounding item, that the sacraments are necessary for salvation, states a proposition the Reformed confessions deny and is null on this score. The coefficient is unchanged by controlling the pastor’s own biblical literalism and theological self-placement (+0.2111 with both). Confessional binding is a property of a denomination rather than of a pastor, so column (3) reports the dispersion of the same item where it lives: one observation per body, the outcome being the standard deviation of agreement among that body’s clergy. The two columns are the individual and the collective face of one prediction. Both are identified off a narrow range of the score, with a single body at zero: dropping the Churches of Christ, the only such body, leaves +0.1274 (0.1136) in column (2) and –0.0426 (0.1018) in column (3), and that body’s disagreement is concentrated in a fifth of its clergy who reject the item’s premillennial phrasing, *return to earth*, rather than the proposition of the creeds. An individual-level absolute-deviation version of column (3) is not reported: 68 per cent of pastors sit at the top of the scale, so the denominational mean and the mean absolute deviation correlate at –0.898 and at the individual level the dispersion is not separable from the level. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered on denomination, except in column (3), where the observation is the denomination and the ordinary standard error is reported.

Table SI-4: Denominational institutionalization and religious behavior I: private devotion

	Reads scripture		Prays more often		Born-again		Rel. exp. changed life
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	
DII (raw, 0–12)	-0.0313** (0.0099)	-0.0415*** (0.0060)	-0.0136** (0.0043)	-0.0277*** (0.0041)	-0.0215*** (0.0057)	-0.0265*** (0.0044)	-0.0081* (0.0040)
Attendance	0.2271*** (0.0245)	0.3972*** (0.0080)	0.1539*** (0.0067)	0.2219*** (0.0121)	0.0475*** (0.0030)	0.0684*** (0.0040)	0.0389*** (0.0041)
Strength of affiliation	0.4168*** (0.0413)	—	0.3340*** (0.0274)	—	0.0804*** (0.0099)	—	0.0844*** (0.0158)
Importance of religion	—	0.7163*** (0.0158)	—	1.1023*** (0.0342)	—	0.1696*** (0.0119)	—
Ideology	0.1021*** (0.0215)	-0.1119*** (0.0137)	0.0420** (0.0136)	-0.0807*** (0.0170)	0.0228*** (0.0047)	-0.0659*** (0.0079)	0.0265*** (0.0051)
Party identification	0.0008 (0.0197)	0.0221† (0.0124)	0.0083 (0.0064)	0.0212* (0.0090)	0.0042† (0.0023)	-0.0112** (0.0040)	-0.0049 (0.0044)
Education	-0.0603 (0.0386)	-0.0124 (0.0132)	-0.0464*** (0.0121)	-0.0028 (0.0098)	-0.0372*** (0.0095)	-0.0509*** (0.0087)	-0.0117 (0.0102)
Age	0.0061* (0.0028)	0.0114*** (0.0033)	0.0079*** (0.0009)	0.0046 (0.0029)	-0.0006 (0.0005)	0.0023 (0.0015)	-0.0015† (0.0008)
Female	0.2594** (0.0852)	0.1615*** (0.0232)	0.5075*** (0.0376)	0.3836*** (0.0345)	0.0168* (0.0071)	-0.0043 (0.0060)	0.0313* (0.0119)
Black	0.3398* (0.1550)	0.2186*** (0.0435)	0.3372*** (0.0331)	0.0539 (0.0367)	0.0613† (0.0360)	0.0469 (0.0316)	0.0408 (0.0355)
Other race	0.1584 (0.2827)	0.1626*** (0.0390)	0.1002 (0.0611)	0.0757* (0.0368)	0.0240 (0.0230)	0.0484* (0.0227)	-0.0905* (0.0412)
Hispanic	—	0.1733*** (0.0475)	0.1930** (0.0593)	0.0982† (0.0548)	0.0937** (0.0293)	0.0835*** (0.0235)	0.1972*** (0.0296)
Fixed effects	Division + year	State + wave	Division + year	State + wave	Division + year	State + wave	Division + year
Observations	1,299	24,503	16,664	24,458	10,221	24,054	4,343
Denominations (clusters)	39	75	50	75	49	75	46
DV mean	2.765	3.686	4.644	5.815	0.591	0.601	0.504
DV SD	1.546	1.528	1.417	1.581	0.492	0.490	0.500
Data source	GSS	RLS 2007+14	GSS	RLS 2007+14	GSS	RLS 2007+14	GSS

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. U.S. Protestants. All estimates are OLS with every dependent variable on its native scale, coded so that higher values indicate more of the practice: scripture reading is a 6-point scale in the GSS and a 5-point scale in the RLS, prayer frequency a 6-point scale in the GSS and a 7-point scale in the RLS, and the born-again and life-changing-experience items binary 0/1. GSS models control for attendance, strength of religious affiliation, ideology, party identification, education, age, and sex, with census-division and survey-year fixed effects. RLS models pool the 2007 and 2014 waves with wave fixed effects, replace strength of affiliation with importance of religion, and carry state fixed effects; education is harmonized to five common levels across the waves' differing category frames (less than high school; high school graduate; some college, vocational, or associate; four-year degree; postgraduate), and age enters as the 15-band grouping released in 2014, with 2007 ages cut to the same bands. Race indicators are included, with white non-Hispanic as the reference, the Hispanic indicator dropped where it does not vary. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered on denomination.

Table SI-5: Denominational institutionalization and religious behavior II: congregational participation

	Official member	Volunteers through church	Church-affiliated group member	Social activities at church	Choir or musical program	Works with children/youth	Church activ. beyond services
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
DII (raw, 0–12)	0.0084*** (0.0021)	0.0205*** (0.0029)	0.0042** (0.0014)	0.0076* (0.0032)	0.0029 (0.0051)	-0.0024 (0.0045)	0.0055 (0.0056)
Attendance	0.1407*** (0.0059)	0.5361*** (0.0126)	0.0967*** (0.0018)	0.6127*** (0.0160)	0.4146*** (0.0137)	0.4711*** (0.0223)	0.5706*** (0.0114)
Strength of affiliation	—	—	0.0728*** (0.0053)	—	—	—	0.3101*** (0.0221)
Importance of religion	0.0853*** (0.0100)	0.2027*** (0.0265)	—	0.2125*** (0.0303)	0.1034*** (0.0247)	0.1169*** (0.0312)	—
Ideology	0.0058† (0.0032)	-0.0187 (0.0127)	0.0055† (0.0028)	-0.0113 (0.0151)	-0.0026 (0.0131)	-0.0356** (0.0106)	-0.0246 (0.0203)
Party identification	-0.0159*** (0.0031)	0.0244 (0.0164)	0.0035* (0.0015)	-0.0076 (0.0130)	0.0302* (0.0133)	0.0060 (0.0119)	0.0188* (0.0092)
Education	0.0194*** (0.0024)	0.0654*** (0.0154)	0.0381*** (0.0050)	0.0466*** (0.0095)	0.0229 (0.0162)	0.0477*** (0.0114)	0.1295*** (0.0259)
Age	0.0045*** (0.0012)	-0.0118*** (0.0031)	0.0018*** (0.0002)	-0.0083** (0.0027)	-0.0275*** (0.0035)	-0.1229*** (0.0037)	-0.0008 (0.0012)
Female	-0.0100† (0.0054)	-0.0633** (0.0215)	0.0287** (0.0086)	-0.0300 (0.0193)	-0.0453* (0.0199)	0.0389† (0.0207)	0.0535 (0.0355)
Black	0.0519*** (0.0116)	0.2048*** (0.0535)	0.0323** (0.0114)	0.0954† (0.0512)	0.4997*** (0.0601)	0.2934*** (0.0795)	0.0814 (0.0718)
Other race	-0.0020 (0.0136)	0.1189** (0.0356)	-0.0448 (0.0412)	0.0692 (0.0586)	0.1389* (0.0666)	0.1752** (0.0566)	0.0649 (0.1037)
Hispanic	0.0085 (0.0149)	0.1324* (0.0609)	—	-0.0054 (0.0763)	0.1015 (0.1052)	0.0548 (0.0613)	-0.1327 (0.1090)
Fixed effects	State + wave	State	Division + year	State	State	State	Division + year
Observations	24,578	11,174	9,928	11,194	11,195	11,205	8,885
Denominations (clusters)	75	72	48	72	72	72	49
DV mean	0.725	2.626	0.420	3.185	1.838	2.324	3.641
DV SD	0.446	1.350	0.494	1.290	1.452	1.501	2.505
Data source	RLS 2007+14	RLS 2007	GSS	RLS 2007	RLS 2007	RLS 2007	GSS

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. U.S. Protestants; specifications identical to Table SI-4. Official membership is asked of all respondents in both RLS waves (2007 of the respondent or their family, 2014 of the respondent personally; the wave fixed effect absorbs the level difference) and is coded 1 if yes. The four church-activity items (volunteering through one's place of worship, social activities, choir or musical programs, and work with children or youth) form the complete 2007 battery, asked of respondents who attend services at least a few times a year, on 5-point frequency scales; every item of the battery is reported. Church-affiliated group membership is from the GSS voluntary-associations module (1974–1994 and 2004), coded 1 if the respondent belongs to a church-affiliated group. Church activities beyond services is the GSS 11-point frequency item on taking part in church activities other than attending services. Race indicators are included, with white non-Hispanic as the reference, the Hispanic indicator dropped where it does not vary. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered on denomination.

C.2 DII and Institutional Trust

C.3 DII and Populism

D Robustness and Additional Analysis

D.1 Theology Controlled

D.2 Dropping the Family-Fallback Respondents

D.3 Dropping the Nondenominational Cell

D.4 The Attendance Dose

D.5 Nativism and Racial Resentment

Table SI-6: Denominational institutionalization and confidence in institutions (GSS)

Confidence in... (1–3, higher = more confidence)									
	Supreme Court (1)	Executive branch (2)	Congress (3)	Press (4)	Tele- vision (5)	Educa- tion (6)	Scientific community (7)	Medi- cine (8)	Organized religion (9)
DII (raw, 0–12)	0.0109*** (0.0020)	0.0031* (0.0012)	0.0003 (0.0009)	0.0062*** (0.0011)	0.0053** (0.0018)	0.0051** (0.0019)	0.0078** (0.0025)	0.0068*** (0.0011)	0.0095** (0.0033)
Attendance	-0.0013 (0.0027)	0.0153*** (0.0023)	0.0155*** (0.0019)	-0.0054** (0.0016)	-0.0215*** (0.0022)	0.0119*** (0.0031)	-0.0117** (0.0040)	0.0052* (0.0025)	0.0514*** (0.0047)
Ideology	-0.0147*** (0.0032)	-0.0175** (0.0053)	-0.0105* (0.0039)	-0.0498*** (0.0084)	-0.0288*** (0.0069)	-0.0259*** (0.0068)	-0.0182** (0.0054)	-0.0059 (0.0052)	0.0032 (0.0050)
Party identification	0.0092** (0.0030)	0.0092† (0.0046)	-0.0097*** (0.0026)	-0.0340*** (0.0034)	-0.0130*** (0.0016)	-0.0122** (0.0039)	-0.0039 (0.0029)	0.0013 (0.0029)	0.0134*** (0.0030)
Education	0.0614*** (0.0075)	0.0320*** (0.0059)	0.0016 (0.0066)	0.0033 (0.0051)	-0.0333*** (0.0064)	0.0048 (0.0057)	0.0863*** (0.0046)	0.0299*** (0.0057)	0.0003 (0.0059)
Age	-0.0011* (0.0004)	-0.0001 (0.0003)	-0.0020*** (0.0004)	-0.0001 (0.0003)	0.0002 (0.0003)	0.0007* (0.0003)	-0.0005* (0.0002)	-0.0020*** (0.0005)	0.0008* (0.0004)
Female	-0.0369*** (0.0101)	-0.0063 (0.0106)	0.0276* (0.0135)	-0.0080 (0.0089)	-0.0186* (0.0084)	0.0015 (0.0129)	-0.0662*** (0.0074)	-0.0456*** (0.0091)	-0.0118 (0.0133)
Log family income	0.0080 (0.0083)	-0.0062 (0.0061)	-0.0208*** (0.0050)	-0.0297*** (0.0055)	-0.0402*** (0.0049)	-0.0322*** (0.0052)	0.0333*** (0.0051)	0.0089† (0.0051)	-0.0138* (0.0056)
Black	-0.0332† (0.0196)	0.0120 (0.0143)	0.0161 (0.0128)	0.0192 (0.0158)	0.1180*** (0.0152)	0.1018*** (0.0233)	-0.1531*** (0.0191)	-0.0236 (0.0153)	0.0433† (0.0230)
Other race	0.0821*** (0.0196)	0.1173** (0.0428)	0.1502*** (0.0294)	0.1462*** (0.0402)	0.0876*** (0.0224)	0.1012** (0.0359)	-0.0166 (0.0164)	-0.0276 (0.0197)	0.0208 (0.0445)
Hispanic	0.0063 (0.0283)	0.1160** (0.0377)	0.1028** (0.0343)	-0.0175 (0.0213)	-0.0486† (0.0276)	0.0612* (0.0300)	0.0278 (0.0401)	-0.0705** (0.0202)	-0.0545* (0.0206)
Observations	20,074	20,335	20,334	20,434	20,454	20,450	19,468	20,508	20,161
Denominations (clusters)	52	52	52	52	52	52	52	52	52
DV mean	2.149	1.819	1.775	1.798	1.782	2.156	2.319	2.377	2.128
DV SD	0.670	0.682	0.629	0.675	0.649	0.647	0.616	0.632	0.665

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. U.S. Protestants, GSS 1973–2022 (the 2024 wave lacks the detailed denomination codes in the current cumulative release). The columns are the GSS confidence items of Table 4, each on its native 3-point scale reversed so that higher values indicate more confidence. All models are OLS with controls for attendance, ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, and log real family income (constant dollars), with census-division and survey-year fixed effects. Adding it moves the Supreme Court coefficient from 0.0109 to 0.0116 on a sample 8% smaller, and no estimate changes by more than 0.001. Race indicators are included, with white non-Hispanic as the reference, the Hispanic indicator dropped where it does not vary. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered on denomination.

Table SI-7: Affect toward institutions, ANES cumulative file (full coefficients)

Feeling thermometers (0–97) and the media-fairness / Congress-approval items

	Supreme Court (1)	Federal govt (2)	Con- gress (3)	Media fairness (4)	Congress approval (5)
DII (raw, 0–12)	0.1468*** (0.0294)	0.1647* (0.0794)	0.0305 (0.0716)	0.0096* (0.0037)	0.0030** (0.0011)
Attendance	-0.0776 (0.1260)	0.6144** (0.2257)	0.5120** (0.1608)	-0.0124 (0.0129)	0.0027 (0.0025)
Ideology	0.6856*** (0.1741)	-1.2998*** (0.2776)	0.0239 (0.1703)	-0.0718*** (0.0167)	-0.0077* (0.0036)
Party identification	0.4224** (0.1412)	-0.9072*** (0.1955)	-0.3163** (0.1073)	-0.0252*** (0.0062)	-0.0037 (0.0028)
Education	0.2455 (0.2600)	-0.8968† (0.4723)	-1.7165*** (0.3413)	-0.0275† (0.0160)	-0.0262*** (0.0045)
Age	0.1261*** (0.0095)	0.0589*** (0.0137)	0.0111 (0.0143)	0.0009 (0.0007)	-0.0036*** (0.0002)
Female	0.7510* (0.3187)	1.2574 (0.8374)	3.5837*** (0.5054)	0.0186 (0.0329)	0.0501*** (0.0077)
Family-income group	0.0399 (0.1730)	-1.0759*** (0.2210)	-1.3031*** (0.1781)	-0.0265 (0.0191)	-0.0185*** (0.0037)
Black	4.2867*** (0.6377)	11.2386*** (1.0097)	6.9122*** (0.4927)	-0.0430 (0.0272)	0.0305* (0.0128)
Other race	0.5387 (0.9522)	5.0731*** (0.8010)	2.9346** (1.0456)	0.0649 (0.1184)	0.0148 (0.0150)
Hispanic	2.1580 (1.4809)	8.7197*** (1.2984)	6.2510*** (1.6198)	0.0340 (0.0576)	0.0621** (0.0187)
Observations	9,257	5,826	9,862	2,262	13,330
Denominations (clusters)	67	61	68	48	67
DV mean	60.88	48.49	48.43	2.17	0.32
DV SD	19.74	22.58	21.68	0.76	0.47

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Full stack behind the ANES cumulative-file cells of Table 4. U.S. Protestants, ANES cumulative file; state and survey-year FE; race controls; SEs clustered on denomination. The matrix (Table 4) reports these DII coefficients divided by the DV standard deviation in the meta rows. Standard errors in parentheses.

Table SI-8: Trust in intermediary institutions, ANES 2024 (full coefficients)

	ANES 2024 scientists (1)	ANES 2024 judiciary (2)	ANES 2024 Congress (3)	ANES 2024 government (4)	ANES 2024 parties (5)	ANES 2024 trad. media (6)	Colleges & universities 2024 (7)
DII (raw, 0–12)	0.0051 (0.0041)	0.0067 (0.0048)	0.0040 (0.0040)	0.0074* (0.0029)	0.0082* (0.0034)	0.0156*** (0.0041)	0.0227** (0.0081)
Attendance	-0.0254*** (0.0062)	0.0063 (0.0063)	0.0088 (0.0056)	0.0136 (0.0085)	0.0202* (0.0082)	0.0105 (0.0090)	0.0176 (0.0236)
Ideology	-0.1126*** (0.0163)	0.0089 (0.0137)	-0.0393* (0.0157)	-0.0656*** (0.0150)	-0.0056 (0.0142)	-0.0968*** (0.0172)	-0.2761*** (0.0306)
Party identification	-0.0905*** (0.0108)	0.0279** (0.0093)	0.0324** (0.0104)	-0.0107 (0.0101)	0.0114 (0.0101)	-0.1133*** (0.0121)	-0.0542† (0.0319)
Education	0.0924*** (0.0237)	0.0469** (0.0151)	0.0017 (0.0144)	0.0436*** (0.0115)	-0.0466*** (0.0126)	0.0062 (0.0129)	0.0037 (0.0602)
Age	0.0026** (0.0008)	0.0060*** (0.0017)	0.0049*** (0.0007)	0.0103*** (0.0008)	0.0062*** (0.0009)	0.0039*** (0.0008)	-0.0077*** (0.0021)
Female	-0.0093 (0.0231)	-0.0036 (0.0305)	0.1306*** (0.0354)	0.0162 (0.0235)	0.1197*** (0.0251)	0.0565 (0.0448)	0.2461* (0.1142)
Family-income group	0.0500** (0.0184)	0.0397** (0.0141)	0.0134 (0.0116)	0.0187 (0.0181)	-0.0193† (0.0102)	0.0156* (0.0073)	-0.0419 (0.0307)
Black	-0.2900*** (0.0750)	-0.0643† (0.0380)	0.0743 (0.0465)	0.0592 (0.0489)	0.1128** (0.0343)	-0.0740 (0.0875)	0.2532 (0.2488)
Other race	-0.1130* (0.0542)	0.0241 (0.0636)	0.0812 (0.0575)	0.1524* (0.0603)	0.2729*** (0.0552)	0.0335 (0.0453)	-0.0147 (0.1295)
Hispanic	0.0674 (0.3548)	-0.1262 (0.4194)	0.5066*** (0.1000)	0.3537 (0.3425)	0.3861† (0.2066)	0.3702* (0.1479)	0.2307 (0.2537)
Observations	1,605	1,603	1,606	1,603	1,602	1,605	1,763
Denominations (clusters)	43	43	43	43	43	43	44
DV mean	3.05	2.70	2.36	2.37	2.22	2.25	3.14
DV SD	0.80	0.72	0.71	0.74	0.72	0.88	1.70

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Full stack behind the ANES 2024 trust cells of Table 4, plus the 2024 approve-how-colleges-and-universities-are-run item of Table 4 (7-point, reversed so higher = approve). U.S. Protestants; state (+ wave) FE; race controls; SEs clustered on denomination; income is the within-wave quintile. Standard errors in parentheses.

Table SI-9: The CES cells of the institution matrix (full coefficients)

	Outcomes standardized (SD units)			
	Local schools	Mayor / city mgr.	City council	Trust federal govt (2022)
DII (raw, 0–12)	0.0085** (0.0030)	0.0064* (0.0024)	0.0052* (0.0023)	0.0111* (0.0045)
Attendance	0.0300*** (0.0048)	0.0413*** (0.0069)	0.0505*** (0.0082)	0.0339*** (0.0052)
Ideology	-0.0287** (0.0099)	-0.0494*** (0.0124)	-0.0385** (0.0119)	-0.1879*** (0.0150)
Party identification	-0.0041 (0.0054)	-0.0023 (0.0069)	-0.0017 (0.0057)	-0.1494*** (0.0098)
Education	0.0047 (0.0058)	0.0098 (0.0066)	0.0026 (0.0060)	-0.0073 (0.0073)
Age	0.0019* (0.0008)	0.0015 [†] (0.0008)	-0.0008 (0.0008)	-0.0006 (0.0008)
Female	-0.0227 (0.0194)	0.0289 (0.0202)	0.0701*** (0.0165)	0.0391 [†] (0.0197)
Family income (z)	0.1001*** (0.0090)	0.0690*** (0.0125)	0.0625*** (0.0127)	-0.0248* (0.0119)
Black	-0.2573*** (0.0216)	-0.0526* (0.0261)	-0.0750* (0.0329)	0.1471*** (0.0346)
Other race	-0.1788*** (0.0373)	-0.1287** (0.0379)	-0.0890* (0.0397)	-0.1974*** (0.0317)
Hispanic	-0.0638 (0.0431)	0.0103 (0.0333)	-0.0552 (0.0451)	0.0540 (0.0388)
Observations	15,330	14,146	14,265	13,212
Denominations (clusters)	78	77	77	77

Notes. [†] $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Full stack behind the CES cells of Table 4. Columns 1–4 are the CES 2016 local report-card battery, reversed so higher = better, then standardized. Column 5 is the CES 2022 trust-in-federal-government item, standardized. U.S. Protestants, state fixed effects. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered on denomination.

Table SI-10: OLS on the common complete-case sample (full coefficients, panel A)

	Confidence in... (1–3, higher = more confidence)								
	Executive branch (1)	Con- gress (2)	Supreme Court (3)	Organized religion (4)	Scientific community (5)	Medi- cine (6)	Educa- tion (7)	Press (8)	Tele- vision (9)
DII (raw, 0–12)	0.0045*** (0.0013)	0.0024† (0.0012)	0.0108*** (0.0022)	0.0097** (0.0033)	0.0084*** (0.0022)	0.0070*** (0.0009)	0.0063** (0.0022)	0.0056*** (0.0014)	0.0050** (0.0017)
Attendance	0.0172*** (0.0031)	0.0169*** (0.0029)	-0.0006 (0.0028)	0.0505*** (0.0052)	-0.0114** (0.0036)	0.0058* (0.0027)	0.0122*** (0.0024)	-0.0057*** (0.0021)	-0.0213*** (0.0030)
Ideology	-0.0090 (0.0074)	-0.0120* (0.0050)	-0.0111* (0.0042)	0.0098* (0.0048)	-0.0178** (0.0059)	-0.0078 (0.0073)	-0.0258*** (0.0074)	-0.0567*** (0.0097)	-0.0245** (0.0080)
Party identification	0.0176*** (0.0045)	-0.0138*** (0.0028)	0.0142*** (0.0040)	0.0151*** (0.0032)	-0.0046 (0.0033)	0.0019 (0.0037)	-0.0100* (0.0049)	-0.0400*** (0.0032)	-0.0133*** (0.0022)
Education	0.0303*** (0.0065)	-0.0050 (0.0080)	0.0557*** (0.0080)	0.0075 (0.0075)	0.0839*** (0.0067)	0.0239** (0.0070)	0.0043 (0.0049)	0.0021 (0.0058)	-0.0276*** (0.0073)
Age	-0.0002 (0.0004)	-0.0021*** (0.0005)	-0.0012* (0.0005)	0.0008 (0.0006)	-0.0003 (0.0003)	-0.0019*** (0.0005)	0.0010* (0.0004)	0.0001 (0.0003)	0.0005 (0.0005)
Female	-0.0100 (0.0117)	0.0324** (0.0117)	-0.0187† (0.0109)	-0.0113 (0.0155)	-0.0552*** (0.0110)	-0.0271* (0.0103)	-0.0028 (0.0157)	-0.0015 (0.0083)	-0.0044 (0.0111)
Log family income	-0.0044 (0.0056)	-0.0213*** (0.0052)	0.0052 (0.0107)	-0.0098 (0.0074)	0.0332*** (0.0058)	0.0137* (0.0062)	-0.0216** (0.0066)	-0.0212*** (0.0058)	-0.0324*** (0.0056)
Black	0.0011 (0.0207)	-0.0141 (0.0175)	-0.0505† (0.0294)	0.0415† (0.0236)	-0.1563*** (0.0209)	-0.0488* (0.0184)	0.0618* (0.0247)	-0.0006 (0.0260)	0.0931*** (0.0186)
Other race	0.0289 (0.0899)	0.0899** (0.0312)	0.0851† (0.0431)	-0.0367 (0.0559)	-0.0467 (0.0292)	-0.0743† (0.0430)	0.0899* (0.0340)	0.0652 (0.0855)	0.0765 (0.0481)
Hispanic	0.1323† (0.0776)	0.1628* (0.0634)	0.0546 (0.0798)	0.0147 (0.0636)	0.0432 (0.0679)	-0.0607 (0.0618)	0.1296** (0.0463)	0.0969 (0.0645)	0.0118 (0.0490)
Observations	11,809	11,810	11,690	11,680	11,342	11,872	11,856	11,837	11,839
Childhood denominations (clusters)	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Panel A of the full stack behind Table 5: the OLS column, estimated on the identical sample as the 2SLS for each outcome. U.S. Protestants raised Protestant, GSS 1973–2022; census-division + survey-year FE; SEs clustered on the adult denomination (the 2SLS panels cluster on the childhood denomination, the level at which the instrument varies). Standard errors in parentheses.

Table SI-11: Childhood-DII 2SLS, baseline specification (full coefficients, panel B)

	Confidence in... (1-3, higher = more confidence)							
	Executive branch (1)	Con- gress (2)	Supreme Court (3)	Organized religion (4)	Scientific community (5)	Medi- cine (6)	Educa- tion (7)	Tele- vision (9)
DII (instrumented)	0.0035 [†] (0.0017)	-0.0012 (0.0023)	0.0111*** (0.0029)	0.0092** (0.0032)	0.0085** (0.0027)	0.0100*** (0.0019)	0.0034 [†] (0.0019)	0.0042 (0.0027)
Attendance	0.0171*** (0.0036)	0.0166*** (0.0028)	-0.0006 (0.0036)	0.0504*** (0.0045)	-0.0114* (0.0044)	0.0061* (0.0025)	0.0119*** (0.0021)	-0.0058* (0.0024)
Ideology	-0.0092 [†] (0.0053)	-0.0127** (0.0044)	-0.0111** (0.0041)	0.0097 [†] (0.0049)	-0.0177*** (0.0045)	-0.0071 (0.0051)	-0.0264** (0.0079)	-0.0570*** (0.0081)
Party identification	0.0176*** (0.0034)	-0.0135*** (0.0033)	0.0142*** (0.0035)	0.0152*** (0.0041)	-0.0046 (0.0030)	0.0016 (0.0030)	-0.0098*** (0.0027)	-0.0399*** (0.0036)
Education	0.0308*** (0.0060)	-0.0032 (0.0059)	0.0555*** (0.0095)	0.0077 (0.0059)	0.0838*** (0.0061)	0.0223* (0.0088)	0.0058 (0.0048)	0.0028 (0.0068)
Age	-0.0002 (0.0004)	-0.0020*** (0.0004)	-0.0012** (0.0004)	0.0008 (0.0005)	-0.0003 (0.0004)	-0.0020*** (0.0005)	0.0011* (0.0004)	0.0001 (0.0003)
Female	-0.0098 (0.0165)	0.0330* (0.0154)	-0.0187 (0.0125)	-0.0113 (0.0151)	-0.0552*** (0.0146)	-0.0276** (0.0094)	-0.0023 (0.0148)	-0.0013 (0.0088)
Log family income	-0.0042 (0.0075)	-0.0207*** (0.0056)	0.0052 (0.0092)	-0.0098 (0.0080)	0.0332*** (0.0031)	0.0132 (0.0091)	-0.0211* (0.0082)	-0.0210** (0.0072)
Black	-0.0007 (0.0147)	-0.0205 (0.0164)	-0.0500** (0.0181)	0.0408* (0.0188)	-0.1561*** (0.0180)	-0.0433*** (0.0137)	0.0565*** (0.0136)	-0.0030 (0.0227)
Other race	0.0282 (0.0828)	0.0878* (0.0369)	0.0853** (0.0299)	-0.0370 (0.0672)	-0.0466 (0.0528)	-0.0724 [†] (0.0370)	0.0880 [†] (0.0440)	0.0644 (0.0959)
Hispanic	0.1327 (0.0858)	0.1639*** (0.0241)	0.0545 (0.0706)	0.0148 (0.0565)	0.0432 (0.0572)	-0.0617 (0.0696)	0.1305** (0.0380)	0.0974 (0.0590)
Observations	11,809	11,810	11,690	11,680	11,342	11,872	11,856	11,837
Childhood denominations (clusters)	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
First-stage F	1175	1142	1123	1118	1109	1137	1157	1193

Notes. [†] $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Panel B: the baseline 2SLS of Table 5, instrumenting adult DII with the DII of the denominator in which the respondent was raised at age 16. Specification and sample as panel A. Standard errors in parentheses.

Table SI-12: Childhood-DII 2SLS with the full childhood-background battery (full coefficients, panel C)

Confidence in... (1-3, higher = more confidence)								
Executive branch (1)	Con- gress (2)	Supreme Court (3)	Organized religion (4)	Scientific community (5)	Medi- cine (6)	Educa- tion (7)	Press (8)	Tele- vision (9)
DII (instrumented)	0.0025 (0.0019)	-0.0008 (0.0025)	0.0091* (0.0035)	0.0058* (0.0023)	0.0093*** (0.0018)	0.0043* (0.0021)	0.0032 (0.0026)	0.0056* (0.0023)
Attendance	0.0173*** (0.0036)	0.0163*** (0.0028)	0.0504*** (0.0045)	-0.0105* (0.0044)	0.0064* (0.0025)	0.0113*** (0.0022)	-0.0054* (0.0025)	-0.0213*** (0.0031)
Ideology	-0.0091† (0.0052)	-0.0129** (0.0046)	0.0098* (0.0048)	-0.0165*** (0.0044)	-0.0070 (0.0051)	-0.0271** (0.0079)	-0.0566*** (0.0078)	-0.0246** (0.0071)
Party identification	0.0169*** (0.0033)	-0.0133*** (0.0035)	0.0150*** (0.0042)	-0.0070* (0.0030)	0.0010 (0.0031)	-0.0088** (0.0028)	-0.0408*** (0.0038)	-0.0130*** (0.0024)
Education	0.0257*** (0.0054)	-0.0021 (0.0048)	0.0063 (0.0054)	0.0673*** (0.0052)	0.0189* (0.0081)	0.0086* (0.0040)	-0.0049 (0.0059)	-0.0270** (0.0086)
Age	0.0003 (0.0004)	-0.0021*** (0.0004)	0.0009 (0.0006)	0.0008† (0.0004)	-0.0018*** (0.0005)	0.0010† (0.0005)	0.0007 (0.0004)	0.0004 (0.0004)
Female	-0.0105 (0.0167)	0.0346* (0.0154)	-0.0188 (0.0147)	-0.0585*** (0.0143)	-0.0278** (0.0092)	0.0003 (0.0153)	-0.0024 (0.0092)	-0.0048 (0.0133)
Log family income	-0.0057 (0.0073)	-0.0203*** (0.0053)	0.0037 (0.0085)	0.0290*** (0.0035)	0.0127 (0.0092)	-0.0200* (0.0080)	-0.0231** (0.0074)	-0.0326*** (0.0081)
Black	0.0078 (0.0179)	-0.0088 (0.0176)	0.0465* (0.0198)	-0.1545*** (0.0177)	-0.0363** (0.0135)	0.0691*** (0.0132)	-0.0072 (0.0253)	0.0895*** (0.0143)
Other race	0.0348 (0.0849)	0.0867* (0.0360)	0.0923** (0.0284)	-0.0332 (0.0561)	-0.0668† (0.0364)	0.0897† (0.0448)	0.0641 (0.0963)	0.0731 (0.0554)
Hispanic	0.1449† (0.0822)	0.1660*** (0.0253)	0.0730 (0.0686)	0.0572 (0.0534)	-0.0544 (0.0690)	0.1509*** (0.0369)	0.1045† (0.0611)	0.0070 (0.0579)
Parental education (years)	0.0039† (0.0022)	-0.0044** (0.0016)	-0.0001 (0.0027)	0.0110*** (0.0022)	0.0014 (0.0017)	0.0003 (0.0024)	0.0068** (0.0022)	-0.0012 (0.0020)
Family income at 16 (1-5)	0.0195* (0.0092)	0.0167** (0.0055)	0.0080 (0.0110)	0.0194** (0.0062)	0.0153* (0.0059)	0.0175* (0.0086)	-0.0016 (0.0080)	0.0019 (0.0054)
Father's occupational prestige	-0.0001 (0.0005)	0.0012* (0.0005)	-0.0001 (0.0006)	0.0010† (0.0005)	0.0001 (0.0004)	-0.0008 (0.0005)	0.0002 (0.0010)	0.0001 (0.0008)
Type of place at 16 (1-6)	-0.0009 (0.0036)	-0.0063 (0.0050)	0.0001 (0.0040)	0.0169** (0.0054)	0.0001 (0.0037)	-0.0194*** (0.0041)	0.0106* (0.0049)	0.0026 (0.0051)
Observations	11,809	11,810	11,690	11,680	11,342	11,872	11,837	11,839
Childhood denominations (clusters)	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
First-stage F	1214	1184	1163	1171	1132	1192	1253	1207

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Panel C: the third column of Table 5, adding the full childhood-background battery and division-at-16 fixed effects. Same sample as panels A and B. Standard errors in parentheses.

Table SI-13: Trust in government, ANES cumulative file (full coefficients)

	Higher = the more trusting response			
	Hardly any crooked	Benefit of all	Trust govt do right	Does not waste
DII (raw, 0–12)	0.0072*** (0.0016)	0.0039*** (0.0008)	0.0053* (0.0023)	0.0047*** (0.0008)
Attendance	-0.0020 (0.0051)	0.0074** (0.0026)	0.0053 (0.0043)	0.0148*** (0.0027)
Ideology	-0.0108 [†] (0.0063)	-0.0018 (0.0034)	-0.0121** (0.0037)	-0.0354*** (0.0047)
Party identification	0.0022 (0.0036)	0.0109*** (0.0030)	-0.0011 (0.0032)	-0.0115*** (0.0021)
Education	0.0589*** (0.0087)	0.0089 (0.0058)	0.0128 [†] (0.0065)	0.0090 (0.0089)
Age	0.0021*** (0.0003)	-0.0005** (0.0002)	-0.0002 (0.0003)	-0.0022*** (0.0002)
Female	-0.0689*** (0.0113)	0.0065 (0.0047)	-0.0150 (0.0115)	0.0301*** (0.0085)
Family-income group	0.0081 [†] (0.0046)	-0.0021 (0.0039)	-0.0102* (0.0040)	-0.0174*** (0.0034)
Black	-0.0296 (0.0251)	0.0329** (0.0111)	-0.0675*** (0.0165)	0.0620*** (0.0128)
Other race	-0.0821** (0.0302)	0.0292 [†] (0.0162)	0.0302 (0.0604)	0.0191 (0.0295)
Hispanic	0.1295*** (0.0240)	0.0682* (0.0287)	0.0561* (0.0219)	0.0501* (0.0192)
Observations	11,509	15,695	11,248	16,287
Denominations (clusters)	63	67	61	68
Years	1972–2012	1972–2024	1972–2012	1972–2024
DV mean	1.61	0.25	2.37	1.30
DV SD	0.64	0.43	0.56	0.49

Notes. [†] $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Full stack behind panel A of Table 6. Specification and coding as there. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered on denomination.

Table SI-14: The people-vs-politicians battery (full coefficients)

	People decide (1)	Do not care (2)	Main problem (3)	Only the rich (4)	Compromise = selling out (5)	Trust- worthy (6)	Trusts experts (7)	Need experts (8)
DII (raw, 0–12)	-0.0087 (0.0052)	-0.0108** (0.0034)	0.0009 (0.0054)	-0.0105 (0.0063)	-0.0163** (0.0060)	0.0109*** (0.0028)	0.0061* (0.0030)	0.0066 (0.0040)
Attendance	-0.0136 (0.0085)	-0.0289* (0.0122)	-0.0350*** (0.0094)	-0.0228** (0.0082)	-0.0107 (0.0126)	0.0236* (0.0101)	-0.0096 (0.0124)	0.0057 (0.0120)
Ideology	0.0043 (0.0122)	0.0515† (0.0287)	0.0747*** (0.0200)	-0.0335* (0.0144)	0.1344*** (0.0171)	-0.0255 (0.0198)	-0.1153*** (0.0256)	-0.1005*** (0.0188)
Party identification	0.0171* (0.0083)	0.0197 (0.0127)	0.0375** (0.0124)	-0.0122 (0.0099)	0.0785*** (0.0100)	-0.0340* (0.0132)	-0.1030*** (0.0157)	-0.0889*** (0.0106)
Education	-0.0802*** (0.0166)	-0.1160*** (0.0161)	-0.0959*** (0.0161)	-0.1110*** (0.0130)	-0.1722*** (0.0143)	0.0175 (0.0124)	0.0958*** (0.0145)	0.0197† (0.0114)
Age	-0.0017 (0.0016)	-0.0043** (0.0014)	-0.0008 (0.0013)	-0.0043* (0.0016)	-0.0027** (0.0008)	0.0070*** (0.0009)	-0.0028* (0.0014)	0.0027*** (0.0009)
Female	0.0261 (0.0332)	-0.0076 (0.0213)	0.0371 (0.0356)	0.0445† (0.0242)	0.0791** (0.0285)	-0.0377 (0.0323)	-0.0964*** (0.0139)	0.0073 (0.0391)
Family-income group	-0.0595*** (0.0150)	-0.0524*** (0.0108)	-0.0249 (0.0185)	-0.0586*** (0.0146)	-0.1062*** (0.0200)	-0.0170 (0.0145)	0.0711*** (0.0114)	0.0286† (0.0150)
Black	0.0766 (0.0533)	0.0727 (0.0521)	0.1698** (0.0536)	0.1650*** (0.0348)	0.3545*** (0.0682)	-0.0346 (0.0581)	-0.2711*** (0.0577)	-0.1058† (0.0579)
Other race	-0.0643† (0.0334)	0.1033* (0.0463)	0.0642 (0.0611)	0.0704 (0.0691)	0.2054* (0.0776)	0.0061 (0.0571)	0.0580 (0.0644)	0.1157* (0.0478)
Hispanic	0.3283*** (0.0700)	0.1036† (0.0550)	0.1418 (0.0866)	0.1541* (0.0762)	0.1343 (0.1046)	-0.0864 (0.1310)	-0.2087 (0.1627)	-0.1023 (0.0934)
Observations	4,006	4,010	4,010	4,010	4,010	4,010	2,722	2,724
Denominations (clusters)	52	52	52	52	52	52	48	48
Waves	2016+2020	2016+2020	2016+2020	2016+2020	2016+2020	2016+2020	2020	2020
DV mean	3.50	3.32	3.28	3.55	2.92	2.40	3.18	3.43
DV SD	1.14	1.11	1.08	1.05	1.18	1.02	1.13	1.04

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Full stack behind panels B and C of Table 6; specification and coding as there. The two expert-reference items are fielded in 2020 only. Standard errors in parentheses.

Table SI-15: Individual theology controls: the GSS confidence battery

Confidence in. . .	Baseline	+ Born-again	+ Literalism	+ Both	N
U.S. Supreme Court	+0.0140*** (0.0039)	+0.0124** (0.0039)	+0.0133*** (0.0036)	+0.0121** (0.0037)	5,933
Executive branch	+0.0031 (0.0027)	+0.0032 (0.0028)	+0.0032 (0.0027)	+0.0032 (0.0028)	5,985
Congress	+0.0024 (0.0020)	+0.0030 (0.0020)	+0.0029 (0.0020)	+0.0032 (0.0020)	5,978
Press	+0.0031* (0.0015)	+0.0031 [†] (0.0017)	+0.0035* (0.0015)	+0.0033* (0.0016)	6,007
Television	+0.0074** (0.0021)	+0.0067** (0.0020)	+0.0078*** (0.0021)	+0.0070** (0.0021)	6,005
Education	+0.0063*** (0.0015)	+0.0060*** (0.0015)	+0.0068*** (0.0014)	+0.0063*** (0.0015)	6,016
Scientific community	+0.0103** (0.0036)	+0.0088* (0.0036)	+0.0090** (0.0032)	+0.0082* (0.0033)	5,819
Medicine	+0.0115*** (0.0031)	+0.0104** (0.0030)	+0.0111*** (0.0030)	+0.0102** (0.0030)	6,026
Organized religion	+0.0090** (0.0027)	+0.0102*** (0.0027)	+0.0101*** (0.0027)	+0.0109*** (0.0027)	5,949

Notes. [†] $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Each cell is the coefficient on the raw DII (0–12), specification as the GSS cells of Table 4 with outcomes on their native 3-point scale. All four columns are estimated on the same complete-case sample per item, requiring the born-again and biblical-literalism items observed. Born-again is a 0/1 self-identification. Literalism is a 0/1 indicator for taking the Bible as the literal word of God. These controls are plausibly post-treatment, so the columns bound the estimate rather than identify it. Standard errors are clustered on denomination.

Table SI-16: Individual theology controls: the ANES trust and populism cells

Outcome	Baseline	+ Born-again	+ Literalism	+ Both	N
<i>ANES trust cells</i>					
ANES 2024: scientists	+0.0048 (0.0043)	+0.0034 (0.0040)	+0.0035 (0.0038)	+0.0028 (0.0037)	1,535
ANES 2024: judiciary	+0.0072 [†] (0.0042)	+0.0060 [†] (0.0034)	+0.0065 (0.0043)	+0.0057 (0.0035)	1,533
ANES 2024: Congress	+0.0039 (0.0040)	+0.0046 (0.0037)	+0.0041 (0.0040)	+0.0047 (0.0037)	1,536
ANES 2024: government	+0.0079** (0.0028)	+0.0062* (0.0031)	+0.0074* (0.0030)	+0.0061 [†] (0.0032)	1,533
ANES 2024: political parties	+0.0074 [†] (0.0038)	+0.0058 (0.0041)	+0.0080* (0.0037)	+0.0062 (0.0039)	1,533
ANES 2024: traditional media	+0.0149*** (0.0039)	+0.0139*** (0.0037)	+0.0141*** (0.0037)	+0.0136*** (0.0036)	1,535
Colleges and universities (2024)	+0.0271*** (0.0072)	+0.0244*** (0.0066)	+0.0258*** (0.0070)	+0.0239*** (0.0065)	1,686
<i>ANES populism</i>					
People, not politicians, decide	-0.0086 (0.0055)	-0.0054 (0.0057)	-0.0073 (0.0057)	-0.0049 (0.0058)	3,831
Politicians do not care	-0.0102** (0.0036)	-0.0085* (0.0033)	-0.0091* (0.0036)	-0.0080* (0.0033)	3,835
Politicians the main problem	+0.0003 (0.0056)	-0.0006 (0.0057)	+0.0013 (0.0052)	-0.0000 (0.0054)	3,835
Politicians care only about rich	-0.0099 (0.0063)	-0.0077 (0.0063)	-0.0089 (0.0062)	-0.0073 (0.0063)	3,835
Compromise is selling out	-0.0178** (0.0064)	-0.0145* (0.0059)	-0.0133* (0.0053)	-0.0122* (0.0051)	3,835
Most politicians trustworthy	+0.0112*** (0.0032)	+0.0096** (0.0029)	+0.0119*** (0.0032)	+0.0101** (0.0029)	3,835
Trusts experts over ordinary people	+0.0078* (0.0030)	+0.0088* (0.0040)	+0.0068* (0.0025)	+0.0081* (0.0037)	2,562
Ordinary people need experts	+0.0079 (0.0048)	+0.0078 (0.0048)	+0.0072 (0.0051)	+0.0074 (0.0050)	2,564

Notes. [†] $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Each cell is the coefficient on the raw DII (0–12), specifications as the corresponding cells of Tables 4 and 6 with outcomes on their native scales. All four columns are estimated on the same complete-case sample per outcome, requiring the wave’s born-again and biblical-literalism items observed. Standard errors are clustered on denomination.

Table SI-17: Individual theology controls: the CES 2016 local cells

Rating of . .	Baseline	+ Born-again	N
Local schools	+0.0083** (0.0030)	+0.0084* (0.0033)	15,323
Mayor / city manager	+0.0063** (0.0024)	+0.0062* (0.0027)	14,139
City council	+0.0048* (0.0021)	+0.0056* (0.0024)	14,258

Notes. $\dagger p < .10$, $* p < .05$, $** p < .01$, $*** p < .001$. Each cell is the coefficient on the raw DII (0–12), specification as the CES cells of Table 4 with the A–F grades reversed to their native 5-point scale so that higher is better. Both columns are estimated on the complete-case sample requiring the born-again item observed. Born-again is a 0/1 self-identification. The CES carries no biblical-literalism item, so born-again is the one individual theology control available. Standard errors are clustered on denomination.

Table SI-18: Restricting to the years with detailed denomination codes

Outcome	Full sample			Detailed-code years		
	DII	(SE)	N	DII	(SE)	N
<i>GSS confidence (detailed codes from 1984)</i>						
U.S. Supreme Court	+0.0109***	(0.0020)	20,074	+0.0124***	(0.0020)	14,137
Executive branch	+0.0031*	(0.0012)	20,335	+0.0029 $\dagger$	(0.0015)	14,299
Congress	+0.0003	(0.0009)	20,334	+0.0007	(0.0018)	14,302
Organized religion	+0.0095**	(0.0033)	20,161	+0.0096**	(0.0030)	14,222
Scientific community	+0.0078**	(0.0025)	19,468	+0.0079**	(0.0028)	13,839
Medicine	+0.0068***	(0.0011)	20,508	+0.0096***	(0.0014)	14,409
Press	+0.0062***	(0.0011)	20,434	+0.0068***	(0.0013)	14,363
Television	+0.0053**	(0.0018)	20,454	+0.0062**	(0.0019)	14,380
Education	+0.0051**	(0.0019)	20,450	+0.0059**	(0.0018)	14,380
<i>ANES cumulative (detailed codes from 1990)</i>						
Thermometer: Supreme Court	+0.1468***	(0.0294)	9,257	+0.1623***	(0.0426)	7,440
Thermometer: federal government	+0.1647*	(0.0794)	5,826	+0.1576 $\dagger$	(0.0891)	4,673
Thermometer: Congress	+0.0305	(0.0716)	9,862	+0.0295	(0.0766)	8,714
Trusts government to do right	+0.0053*	(0.0023)	11,248	+0.0063**	(0.0020)	5,204
Government run for benefit of all	+0.0039***	(0.0008)	15,695	+0.0035***	(0.0008)	10,431
Government does not waste taxes	+0.0047***	(0.0008)	16,287	+0.0043**	(0.0012)	10,642
Hardly any officials crooked	+0.0072***	(0.0016)	11,509	+0.0080***	(0.0018)	6,435

Notes. $\dagger p < .10$, $* p < .05$, $** p < .01$, $*** p < .001$. Each row compares the specification of Table 4 on the full sample with the same model restricted to the years in which the survey probes specific denominational bodies: 1984 and later in the GSS, 1990 and later in the ANES. Before those years most Protestants carry only a family-level code and score by the family fallback. The restriction changes the survey instrument, not the respondents, so it bounds the contribution of the family fill without selecting on who names a body. Outcomes on their native scales. Standard errors are clustered on denomination.

Table SI-19: Dropping the nondenominational cell

Outcome	Full sample			Nondenominational dropped		
	DII	(SE)	N	DII	(SE)	N
<i>GSS confidence</i>						
U.S. Supreme Court	+0.0109***	(0.0020)	20,074	+0.0135***	(0.0017)	17,780
Executive branch	+0.0031*	(0.0012)	20,335	+0.0042**	(0.0012)	18,020
Congress	+0.0003	(0.0009)	20,334	-0.0005	(0.0010)	18,029
Organized religion	+0.0095**	(0.0033)	20,161	+0.0060*	(0.0029)	17,881
Scientific community	+0.0078**	(0.0025)	19,468	+0.0109***	(0.0019)	17,225
Medicine	+0.0068***	(0.0011)	20,508	+0.0064***	(0.0015)	18,186
Press	+0.0062***	(0.0011)	20,434	+0.0056**	(0.0020)	18,117
Television	+0.0053**	(0.0018)	20,454	+0.0031 [†]	(0.0017)	18,143
Education	+0.0051**	(0.0019)	20,450	+0.0026*	(0.0011)	18,126
<i>ANES cumulative</i>						
Thermometer: Supreme Court	+0.1468***	(0.0294)	9,257	+0.1342**	(0.0453)	7,841
Thermometer: federal government	+0.1647*	(0.0794)	5,826	+0.0962	(0.1057)	5,066
Thermometer: Congress	+0.0305	(0.0716)	9,862	-0.0914 [†]	(0.0505)	8,369
Trusts government to do right	+0.0053*	(0.0023)	11,248	+0.0026*	(0.0011)	10,181
Government run for benefit of all	+0.0039***	(0.0008)	15,695	+0.0031**	(0.0010)	13,675
Government does not waste taxes	+0.0047***	(0.0008)	16,287	+0.0050**	(0.0015)	14,203
Hardly any officials crooked	+0.0072***	(0.0016)	11,509	+0.0066**	(0.0024)	10,303
<i>ANES waves</i>						
ANES 2024: scientists	+0.0051	(0.0041)	1,605	+0.0056	(0.0045)	1,546
ANES 2024: judiciary	+0.0067	(0.0048)	1,603	+0.0060	(0.0050)	1,544
ANES 2024: Congress	+0.0040	(0.0040)	1,606	+0.0030	(0.0038)	1,547
ANES 2024: government	+0.0074*	(0.0029)	1,603	+0.0083**	(0.0030)	1,544
ANES 2024: political parties	+0.0082*	(0.0034)	1,602	+0.0082*	(0.0034)	1,543
ANES 2024: traditional media	+0.0156***	(0.0041)	1,605	+0.0139***	(0.0037)	1,546
Colleges and universities (2024)	+0.0227**	(0.0081)	1,763	+0.0192**	(0.0064)	1,700
<i>ANES populism</i>						
People, not politicians, decide	-0.0087	(0.0052)	4,006	-0.0093	(0.0059)	3,337
Politicians do not care	-0.0108**	(0.0034)	4,010	-0.0128**	(0.0038)	3,341
Politicians the main problem	+0.0009	(0.0054)	4,010	-0.0002	(0.0065)	3,340
Politicians care only about rich	-0.0105	(0.0063)	4,010	-0.0150*	(0.0067)	3,340
Compromise is selling out	-0.0163**	(0.0060)	4,010	-0.0222**	(0.0078)	3,340
Most politicians trustworthy	+0.0109***	(0.0028)	4,010	+0.0100**	(0.0032)	3,341
Trusts experts over ordinary people	+0.0061*	(0.0030)	2,722	+0.0060	(0.0043)	2,306
Ordinary people need experts	+0.0066	(0.0040)	2,724	+0.0058	(0.0046)	2,307
<i>CES 2016 local (standardized)</i>						
Local schools	+0.0085**	(0.0030)	15,330	+0.0060 [†]	(0.0033)	13,339
Mayor / city manager	+0.0064*	(0.0024)	14,146	+0.0045 [†]	(0.0027)	12,291
City council	+0.0052*	(0.0023)	14,265	+0.0033	(0.0021)	12,398

Notes. [†] $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Each row compares the specification of Tables 4 and 6 on the full sample with the same model after dropping every nondenominational entity. GSS and ANES outcomes on their native scales, CES outcomes standardized as in Table 4. Standard errors are clustered on denomination.

Table SI-20: The attendance dose: DII $\times$ attendance across the institution matrix

	GSS confidence		ANES thermometer		ANES 2024 trust		CES rating / trust	
	DII at mean att.	DII $\times$ att. (SD)	DII at mean att.	DII $\times$ att. (SD)	DII at mean att.	DII $\times$ att. (SD)	DII at mean att.	DII $\times$ att. (SD)
<i>1. National political branches</i>								
Executive / federal govt	0.0049** (0.0018)	0.0052** (0.0016), n=20,335	0.0074* (0.0035)	0.0049 (0.0032), n=5,826	0.0104** (0.0039)	0.0063 [†] (0.0034), n=1,603	0.0095* (0.0045)	0.0007 (0.0022), n=13,212
Congress	0.0008 (0.0016)	0.0043*** (0.0010), n=20,334	0.0015 (0.0033)	0.0024 (0.0025), n=9,862	0.0054 (0.0058)	-0.0032 (0.0036), n=1,606	—	—
U.S. Supreme Court	0.0167*** (0.0030)	0.0065*** (0.0014), n=20,074	0.0076*** (0.0015)	0.0053* (0.0021), n=9,257	0.0093 (0.0068)	-0.0007 (0.0045), n=1,603	—	—
Political parties	—	—	—	—	0.0118* (0.0047)	0.0039 (0.0039), n=1,602	—	—
<i>2. Local political bodies</i>								
Mayor / city manager	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.0064* (0.0025)	0.0008 (0.0033), n=14,146
City council	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.0052* (0.0023)	-0.0006 (0.0034), n=14,265
<i>3. Non-political bodies</i>								
Organized religion	0.0151** (0.0051)	0.0126** (0.0039), n=20,161	—	—	—	—	—	—
Scientific community	0.0133** (0.0039)	0.0092** (0.0027), n=19,468	—	—	0.0065 (0.0051)	0.0011 (0.0026), n=1,605	—	—
Medicine	0.0111*** (0.0018)	0.0046* (0.0018), n=20,508	—	—	—	—	—	—
Education	0.0082* (0.0031)	0.0054* (0.0021), n=20,450	—	—	—	—	—	—
Colleges and universities	—	—	—	—	0.0142** (0.0049)	0.0130* (0.0056), n=1,763	—	—
Local schools	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.0084** (0.0031)	-0.0013 (0.0022), n=15,330
Press / traditional media	0.0093*** (0.0017)	0.0012 (0.0012), n=20,434	—	—	0.0180*** (0.0046)	0.0030 (0.0027), n=1,605	—	—
Television	0.0082** (0.0029)	0.0013 (0.0022), n=20,454	—	—	—	—	—	—

Notes. [†] $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. OLS only. Each pair of columns reports, from a single regression per cell, the coefficient on raw DII at mean attendance and the DII $\times$ attendance interaction, with attendance standardized on the estimation sample and the outcome standardized; controls, fixed effects, samples, and clustering exactly as the corresponding cells of Table 4. The interaction reads as the change in the DII effect (in SD of the outcome per index point) per one-SD increase in church attendance.

Table SI-21: The attendance dose in the populist-sentiment items (ANES)

	DII at mean att.	(SE)	DII × att. (SD)	(SE)	N
<i>A. Trust in government (cumulative file; outcomes standardized)</i>					
Trusts government to do what is right	0.0096*	(0.0042)	0.0032	(0.0031)	11,248
Government run for the benefit of all	0.0091***	(0.0020)	0.0033	(0.0020)	15,695
Government does not waste tax money	0.0096***	(0.0018)	0.0023 [†]	(0.0013)	16,287
Hardly any officials are crooked	0.0112***	(0.0025)	0.0033	(0.0024)	11,509
<i>B. The people-vs-politicians battery (2016 + 2020; outcomes standardized)</i>					
People, not politicians, should decide policy	-0.0078 [†]	(0.0045)	-0.0010	(0.0031)	4,006
Most politicians do not care about the people	-0.0096**	(0.0032)	0.0010	(0.0037)	4,010
Politicians are the main problem in the U.S.	0.0011	(0.0050)	0.0031	(0.0037)	4,010
Politicians care only about the rich and powerful	-0.0099	(0.0060)	0.0010	(0.0036)	4,010
Compromise in politics is selling out	-0.0145**	(0.0054)	-0.0067	(0.0047)	4,010
Most politicians are trustworthy	0.0107***	(0.0028)	-0.0001	(0.0031)	4,010

Notes. [†] $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. OLS only; specifications as Table 6 with outcomes standardized, attendance standardized on each estimation sample, and the DII × attendance interaction added. The first coefficient is the DII effect at mean attendance; the interaction is the change in that effect per one-SD increase in attendance.

Table SI-22: The attendance dose, GSS confidence items (full coefficients)

	Confidence in... (standardized)								
	Exec. (1)	Congr. (2)	S. Ct. (3)	Press (4)	TV (5)	Educ. (6)	Sci. (7)	Med. (8)	Relig. (9)
DII (at mean attendance)	0.0049** (0.0018)	0.0008 (0.0016)	0.0167*** (0.0030)	0.0093*** (0.0017)	0.0082** (0.0029)	0.0082* (0.0031)	0.0133** (0.0039)	0.0111*** (0.0018)	0.0151** (0.0051)
Attendance (SD)	0.0291* (0.0126)	0.0397*** (0.0061)	-0.0414*** (0.0070)	-0.0275** (0.0091)	-0.0929*** (0.0110)	0.0177† (0.0096)	-0.1007*** (0.0207)	-0.0043 (0.0156)	0.1298*** (0.0284)
DII × attendance	0.0052** (0.0016)	0.0043*** (0.0010)	0.0065*** (0.0014)	0.0012 (0.0012)	0.0013 (0.0022)	0.0054* (0.0021)	0.0092** (0.0027)	0.0046* (0.0018)	0.0126** (0.0039)
Ideology	-0.0251** (0.0077)	-0.0162* (0.0061)	-0.0213*** (0.0047)	-0.0737*** (0.0124)	-0.0442*** (0.0106)	-0.0394*** (0.0104)	-0.0285** (0.0083)	-0.0088 (0.0082)	0.0062 (0.0076)
Party identification	0.0135† (0.0067)	-0.0155*** (0.0040)	0.0136** (0.0045)	-0.0504*** (0.0050)	-0.0200*** (0.0024)	-0.0189** (0.0059)	-0.0064 (0.0045)	0.0020 (0.0045)	0.0201*** (0.0045)
Education (degree)	0.0472*** (0.0087)	0.0028 (0.0105)	0.0919*** (0.0112)	0.0050 (0.0076)	-0.0512*** (0.0100)	0.0078 (0.0089)	0.1406*** (0.0075)	0.0475*** (0.0089)	0.0011 (0.0088)
Age	-0.0001 (0.0004)	-0.0032*** (0.0006)	-0.0017* (0.0006)	-0.0001 (0.0004)	0.0002 (0.0004)	0.0011* (0.0004)	-0.0009** (0.0003)	-0.0032*** (0.0007)	0.0012* (0.0006)
Female	-0.0088 (0.0154)	0.0443* (0.0214)	-0.0547*** (0.0149)	-0.0117 (0.0132)	-0.0286* (0.0130)	0.0026 (0.0199)	-0.1069*** (0.0121)	-0.0717*** (0.0141)	-0.0168 (0.0196)
Log real income	-0.0091 (0.0088)	-0.0330*** (0.0080)	0.0119 (0.0123)	-0.0441*** (0.0082)	-0.0620*** (0.0076)	-0.0498*** (0.0080)	0.0541*** (0.0083)	0.0141† (0.0080)	-0.0208* (0.0083)
Black	0.0183 (0.0210)	0.0263 (0.0201)	-0.0485† (0.0286)	0.0286 (0.0233)	0.1821*** (0.0234)	0.1580*** (0.0365)	-0.2471*** (0.0295)	-0.0367 (0.0241)	0.0669† (0.0361)
Other race	0.1732** (0.0627)	0.2398*** (0.0477)	0.1238*** (0.0295)	0.2170*** (0.0593)	0.1354*** (0.0343)	0.1573** (0.0560)	-0.0247 (0.0276)	-0.0429 (0.0316)	0.0348 (0.0685)
Hispanic	0.1720** (0.0558)	0.1649** (0.0545)	0.0115 (0.0428)	-0.0255 (0.0318)	-0.0744† (0.0424)	0.0967* (0.0462)	0.0479 (0.0656)	-0.1098** (0.0317)	-0.0776* (0.0308)
Observations	20,335	20,334	20,074	20,434	20,454	20,450	19,468	20,508	20,161

Notes. † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Full coefficients behind the GSS columns of Table SI-20. OLS. Outcomes and attendance standardized on each estimation sample; DII enters in raw index points, so the interaction is the change in the DII slope per one-SD increase in attendance. Census-division and survey-year fixed effects; standard errors clustered on the adult denominator. Standard errors in parentheses.

Table SI-23: Nativism and racial resentment: the DII does not predict the exclusionary direction

Item	DII	(SE)	N	Denoms.
<i>CES 2016 immigration (0/1, item selected)</i>				
Grant legal status to employed immigrants (pro)	+0.0014	(0.0014)	18,088	79
Increase border patrols (anti)	-0.0027**	(0.0010)	18,088	79
Legal status for those brought as children (pro)	+0.0017	(0.0019)	18,088	79
Fine businesses hiring illegal immigrants (anti)	-0.0010	(0.0016)	3,967	72
Admit no refugees from Syria (anti)	-0.0033	(0.0021)	3,967	72
Increase work visas (pro)	+0.0004	(0.0014)	3,967	72
Identify and deport illegal immigrants (anti)	-0.0020	(0.0020)	18,088	79
Ban Muslims from immigrating (anti)	-0.0008	(0.0019)	3,967	72
<i>CES 2022 racial resentment (1–5, higher = more resentful)</i>				
Minorities should overcome without favors	-0.0023	(0.0044)	13,212	77
Slavery did not create lasting conditions	-0.0112*	(0.0043)	13,211	77
Whites who deny discrimination (mirror)	-0.0031	(0.0080)	3,234	69
Whites get away with offenses (mirror)	+0.0108 [†]	(0.0058)	3,234	69
Whites do not try to understand (mirror)	-0.0065	(0.0051)	3,233	69

Notes. [†] $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Each row is a separate OLS regression of the item on the raw DII (0–12), CES specification as in Table 4: attendance, ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, race, and family income, with state fixed effects and standard errors clustered on denomination. Immigration items are 0/1 for selecting the option. Resentment items are on their native 5-point scale coded so that higher values are more resentful. The three items marked mirror ask about resentment toward Whites and were fielded almost entirely to respondents of color. Half-sample immigration items carry smaller N.

E Catholic Exceptionalism?

Although the main body of the paper focuses on American Protestants, I am also interested in how similar Catholics are to Protestants, and in what respects they differ, especially from Protestants in more institutionalized churches. In particular, I focus on two questions. Do Catholics have higher or lower trust in secular institutions than members of more institutionalized Protestant denominations? And are the differences narrowing among the younger cohorts, as the historical memory of discrimination fades?

To examine these questions, I use the GSS cumulative file, the source with the most comprehensive coverage of institutions and the longest time series, and focus on Catholics and on Protestants whose denominations score 9 or above on the DII. I first regress confidence in each of the nine institutions the GSS covers on a Catholic indicator, with the controls and fixed effects of Table 4. The coefficient can be interpreted as the trust gap between Catholics and Protestants whose churches organize authority in a way most similar to the Catholic Church.

Table SI-24: Catholics against Protestants in highly institutionalized bodies, GSS confidence items

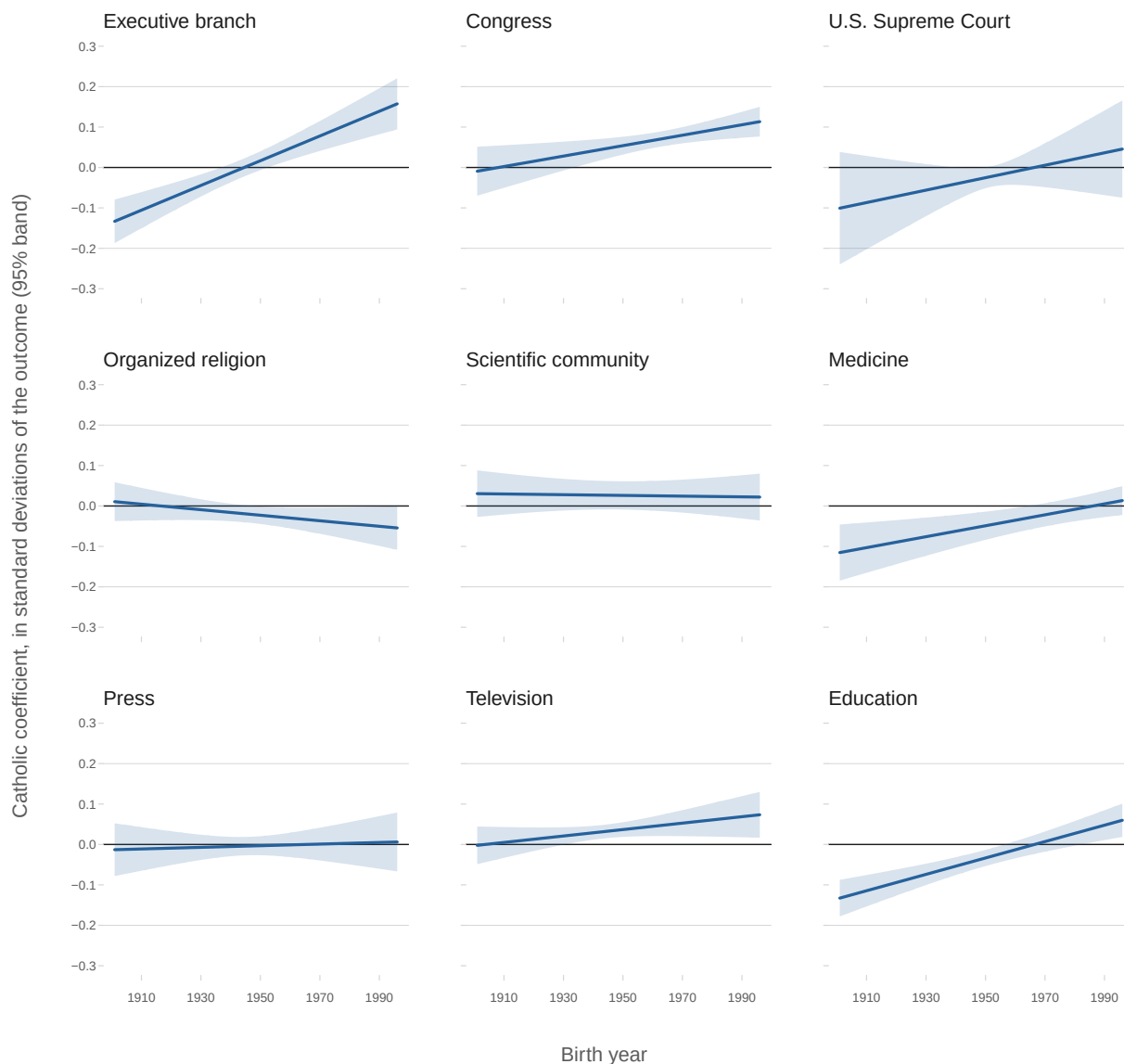
Dependent variable	Coef.	(SE)	N	Catholics
Executive branch	0.0053	(0.0142)	17,582	9,247
Congress	0.0492***	(0.0126)	17,596	9,247
U.S. Supreme Court	-0.0308 [†]	(0.0151)	17,426	9,184
Organized religion	-0.0204 [†]	(0.0112)	17,497	9,226
Scientific community	0.0264	(0.0179)	17,010	9,001
Medicine	-0.0541*	(0.0190)	17,746	9,343
Press	-0.0039	(0.0115)	17,671	9,295
Television	0.0339**	(0.0093)	17,713	9,328
Education	-0.0409**	(0.0135)	17,702	9,328

Notes. [†] $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. GSS 1974 to 2022, Catholics and Protestants in denominations scoring 9 or higher on the index. Each row reports the coefficient on a Catholic indicator, with the outcome standardized. Controls are attendance, ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, log family income, as well as race and ethnicity, with census-division and survey-year fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered on the denomination, with Catholics as one cluster.

Table SI-24 shows that Catholics report less confidence than high-index Protestants in the Supreme Court, organized religion, medicine, and education, and more confidence in Congress and television. The pattern is consistent with the historical experience of Catholics building parallel institutions of their own, especially schools and hospitals.

Figure SI-1, which interacts the Catholic indicator with birth year, shows the difference across cohorts. For the executive branch, Congress, medicine, and education, the Catholic coefficient rises with birth year, with older Catholics trusting these institutions less than their Protestant counterparts and younger Catholics trusting them as much or more. The Supreme Court and television move in the same direction, though the trends are imprecise. Overall, the pattern indicates that the trust gap between Catholics and Protestants existed among older generations and has been closing among younger ones, whose experiences with these institutions are more similar to those of Protestants. The one exception is organized

Figure SI-1: Catholics against high-index Protestants, by birth year



Notes. Each panel plots the coefficient on the Catholic indicator at each birth year from 1901 to 1996, with the Catholic interacted with birth year. Controls are attendance, ideology, party identification, education, age, sex, log family income, as well as race and ethnicity, with census-division and survey-year fixed effects. Shaded areas are 95% confidence bands from standard errors clustered on the denomination.

religion, where the gap widens among younger cohorts, a pattern that could reflect greater exposure to the clerical abuse scandals in recent decades.